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MR LEO NGUYEN
PRISONER OF ZENDA

THE PRISONER OF ZENDA

Rudolf Rassendyll is young, rich, and comes from an old English family. But he has the dark red hair and the long straight nose of the royal family of Ruritania – the result of a little family 'accident' many years before.

Rudolf decides to visit Ruritania for the coronation of the new king. He arrives in the town of Zenda and goes for a quiet walk in the forest. By the next morning he is in the middle of adventures beyond his wildest dreams. With his new friends, Captain Sapt and Fritz von Tarlenheim, he is making plans to rescue the prisoner in the Castle of Zenda. Soon he is fighting the King's enemies, Black Michael the Duke, and Rupert of Hentzau – and falling in love with the King's cousin, the lovely Princess Flavia.

And the King … But who *is* the King of Ruritania?



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The Prisoner of Zenda

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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1

The Rassendylls – and the Elphbergs

‘I wonder when you’re going to do something useful, Rudolf,’ my brother’s wife said. She looked at me crossly over the breakfast table.

‘But why should I do anything, Rose?’ I answered, calmly eating my egg. ‘I’ve got nearly enough money for the things I want, and my brother, Robert, is a lord – Lord Burlesdon. I’m very happy.’

‘You’re twenty-nine, and you’ve done nothing except …’

‘Play about? It’s true. We Rassendylls are a rich and famous family, and we don’t need to do anything.’



‘We Rassendylls don’t need to do anything,’ I said.

This made Rose angry. ‘Rich and famous families usually behave worse than less important families,’ she said.

When I heard this, I touched my dark red hair. I knew what she meant.

‘I’m so pleased that Robert’s hair is black!’ she cried.

Just then my brother, Robert, came in. When he looked at Rose, he could see that there was something wrong.

‘What’s the matter, my dear?’ he said.

‘Oh, she’s angry because I never do anything useful, and because I’ve got red hair,’ I said.

‘Well, I know he can’t do much about his hair, or his nose …’ Rose began.

‘No, the nose and the hair are in the family,’ my brother agreed. ‘And Rudolf has both of them.’

In the room there were many family pictures, and one of them was of a very beautiful

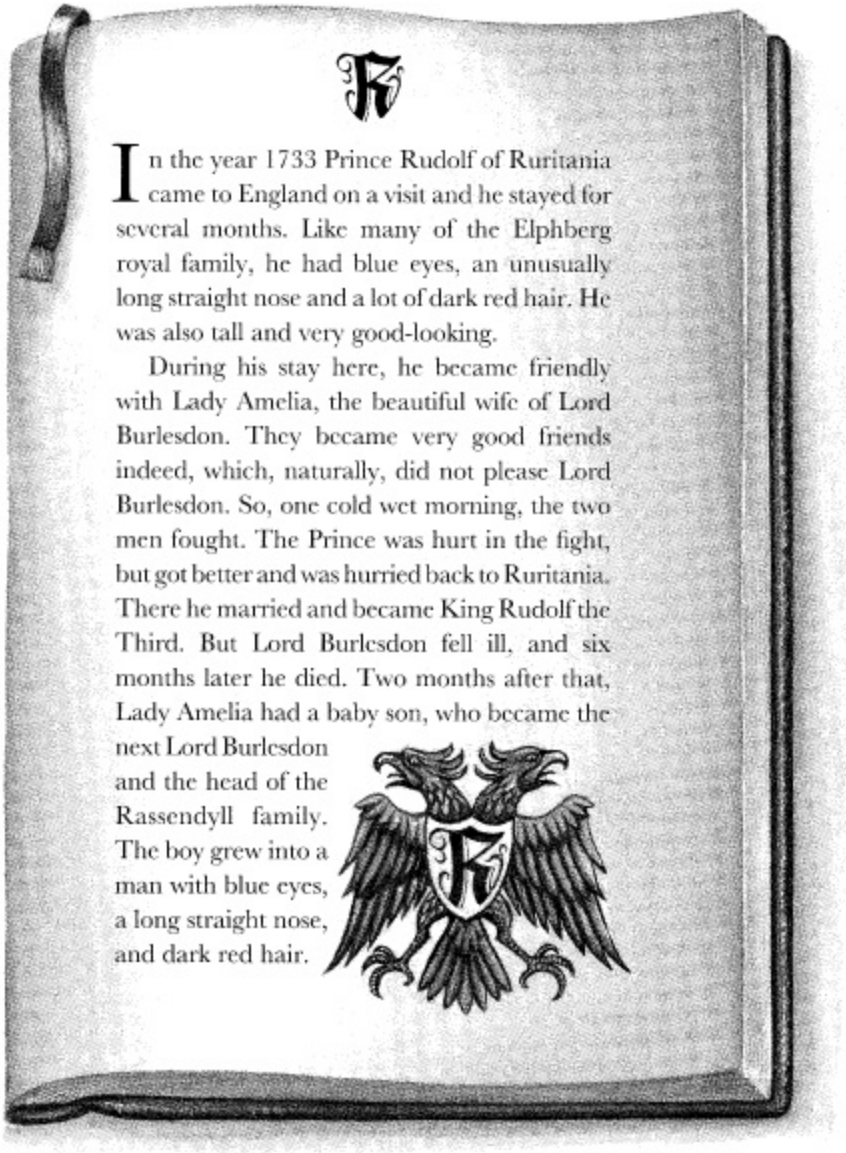
woman, Lady Amelia, who lived a hundred and fifty years ago. I stood up and turned to look at it.

'If you took that picture away, Robert,' Rose cried, 'we could forget all about it.'

'Oh, but I don't want to forget about it,' I replied. 'I like being an Elphberg.'

But perhaps I should stop for a moment and explain why Rose was angry about my nose and my hair – and why I, a Rassendyll, said I was an Elphberg. After all, the Elphbergs are the royal family of Ruritania, and have been for hundreds of years.

The story is told in a book about the Rassendyll family history.



R

In the year 1733 Prince Rudolf of Ruritania came to England on a visit and he stayed for several months. Like many of the Elphberg royal family, he had blue eyes, an unusually long straight nose and a lot of dark red hair. He was also tall and very good-looking.

During his stay here, he became friendly with Lady Amelia, the beautiful wife of Lord Burlesdon. They became very good friends indeed, which, naturally, did not please Lord Burlesdon. So, one cold wet morning, the two men fought. The Prince was hurt in the fight, but got better and was hurried back to Ruritania. There he married and became King Rudolf the Third. But Lord Burlesdon fell ill, and six months later he died. Two months after that, Lady Amelia had a baby son, who became the next Lord Burlesdon and the head of the Rassendyll family. The boy grew into a man with blue eyes, a long straight nose, and dark red hair.

These things can happen in the best of families, and among the many pictures of the Rassendylls at home, you can see that five or six of them have the same blue eyes, the same nose, and the same red hair.

So, because my hair was red and I had the Elphberg nose, Rose worried about me. In the end, to please her, I promised to get a job in six months' time. This gave me six free months to enjoy myself first.

And an idea came to me – I would visit Ruritania. None of my family had ever been

there. They preferred to forget all about the Lady Amelia. But I saw in the newspaper that, in three weeks, the new young King, Rudolf the Fifth, would have his coronation. It would be an interesting time to visit the country.

I knew my family would not like my going, so I told them I was going walking in Austria.

2

The colour of men's hair

On the way to Ruritania I decided to spend a night in Paris with a friend. The next morning he came with me to the station, and as we waited for the train, we watched the crowds. We noticed a tall, dark, very fashionable lady, and my friend told me who she was.



'That's Madame Antoinette de Mauban.'

'That's Madame Antoinette de Mauban. She's travelling on the same train as you, but don't fall in love with her.'

'Why not?' I asked, amused.

'Ah,' said my friend, 'all Paris knows that she's in love with Duke Michael of Strelsau. And he, as you know, is the half-brother of the new King of Ruritania. Although he's only the second son and will never be king himself, he's still an important man and very popular, I hear, with many Ruritanians. The lovely Madame Antoinette won't look twice at you, Rudolf.'

I laughed, but he had woken my interest in the lady. I did not speak to her during the journey, and when we arrived in Ruritania, I left the train at Zenda, a small town outside the capital. But I noticed that Madame de Mauban went on to Strelsau, the capital.

I was welcomed very kindly at my hotel. It belonged to a fat old lady and her pretty daughter. From them I learned that the coronation was to be on the day after next, and not in three weeks.

The old lady was more interested in Duke Michael of Strelsau than in the new King. The Castle of Zenda and all the land around it belonged to the Duke, but the old lady said, 'It's not enough. Duke Michael should be king. He spends all his time with us. Every Ruritanian knows him, but we never see the new King.'

But the daughter cried, 'Oh no, I hate Black Michael. I want a red Elphberg – and the

King, our friend Johann says, is very red. Johann works for the Duke and he's seen the King. In fact, the King's staying just outside Zenda now,' she added. 'He's resting at the Duke's house in the forest before going on to Strelsau on Wednesday for his coronation. The Duke's already in Strelsau, getting everything ready.'

'They're friends?' I asked.

'Friends who want the same place and the same wife,' the pretty girl replied. 'The Duke wants to marry his cousin, Princess Flavia, but people say she's going to be King Rudolf's wife and the Queen.'

Just then their friend, Johann, entered the room.

'We have a visitor, Johann,' the girl's mother said, and Johann turned towards me. But when he saw me, he stepped back, with a look of wonder on his face.

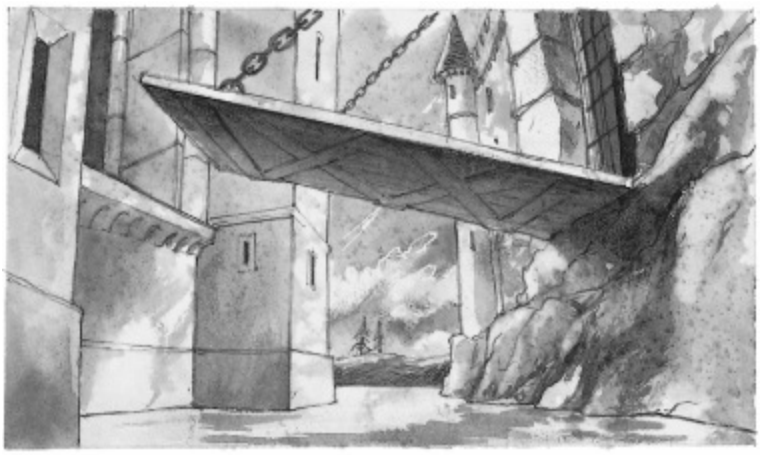
'What's the matter, Johann?' the daughter asked.

'Good evening, sir,' Johann said, still staring at me. He did not seem to like what he saw.

The girl began to laugh. 'It's the colour of your hair, sir,' she explained. 'We don't often see that colour here. It's the Elphberg red – not Johann's favourite colour.'

*

The next day I decided to walk through the forest for a few miles and take the train to Strelsau from a little station along the road. I sent my luggage on by train and after lunch, I started out on foot. First, I wanted to see the Castle of Zenda and in half an hour I had climbed the hill to it. There were two buildings – the old one, with a moat around it, and the new, modern building. Duke Michael could have friends to stay with him in the new castle, but he could go into the old castle when he wanted to be alone. The water in the moat was deep, and if he pulled up the drawbridge over the moat, no one could get to him.



The water in the moat was deep.

I stayed there for some time and looked at the castle, and then I walked on through the forest for about an hour. It was beautiful and I sat down to enjoy it. Before I knew what

had happened, I was asleep.

Suddenly I heard a voice say, 'Good heavens! He looks just like the King!'

When I opened my eyes, there were two men in front of me. One of them came nearer.

'May I ask your name?' he said.

'Well, why don't you tell me your names first?' I replied.

The younger of the two men said, 'This is Captain Sapt, and I am Fritz von Tarlenheim. We work for the King of Ruritania.'

'And I am Rudolf Rassendyll,' I answered, 'a traveller from England. My brother is Lord Burlesdon.'

'Of course! The hair!' Sapt cried. 'You know the story, Fritz?'

Just then a voice called out from the trees behind us. 'Fritz! Fritz! Where are you, man?'

'It's the King!' Fritz said, and Sapt laughed.

Then a young man jumped out from behind a tree. I gave a cry, and when he saw me, he stepped back in sudden surprise. The King of Ruritania looked just like Rudolf Rassendyll, and Rudolf Rassendyll looked just like the King!

For a moment the King said nothing, but then he asked, 'Captain … Fritz … who is this?'

Sapt went to the King and spoke quietly in his ear. The King's surprise changed slowly to an amused smile, then suddenly he began to laugh loudly. 'Well met, cousin!' he cried. 'Where are you travelling to?'

'To Strelsau, sir – to the coronation.'

The King looked at his friends, and, for a moment, he was serious. But then he began to laugh again. 'Wait until brother Michael sees that there are two of us!' he cried.

'Perhaps it isn't a very good idea for Mr Rassendyll to go to Strelsau,' Fritz said, worried, and Sapt agreed with him.

'Oh, we'll think about the coronation tomorrow,' the King said. 'Tonight we'll enjoy ourselves. Come, cousin!'

We returned to the Duke's house in the forest, where we had an excellent dinner. The King called loudly for wine, and Captain Sapt and Fritz seemed worried. Clearly, the King liked his wine a little too much.

'Remember the coronation is tomorrow,' warned old Sapt.



The King liked his wine a little too much.

But the King was only interested in enjoying himself tonight, so we all drank and talked, and drank again. At last the King put down his glass and said, 'I've drunk enough.'

As he said that, old Josef, the King's servant, came in. He put some very special old wine on the table in front of the King and said, 'Duke Michael offers you this wine and asks you to drink it for love of him.'

'Well done, Black Michael!' the King cried. 'Well, I'm not afraid to drink your wine!'

And he drank every drop of wine in the bottle, himself. Then his head fell forward on to the table, and soon afterwards I too remembered no more of that wild evening.

3

The King goes to his coronation

I do not know how long I was asleep, but when I woke up I was cold and wet. Sapt and Fritz stood there looking at me. 'We had to wake you,' Sapt said. 'Cold water was the only way.'

Fritz took my arm and turned me round. 'Look!' he said.

The King was on the floor, and when Sapt pushed him with his foot, he did not move.

'We've been trying to wake him for half an hour,' said Fritz. 'But he's sleeping like a dead man.'

The three of us looked at each other.

'Was there something in that last bottle of wine?' I asked.

'I don't know,' Sapt said, 'but if he doesn't get to his coronation today, there'll never be a coronation for him. All Ruritania is waiting for him in Strelsau and Black Michael with half the army, too. We can't tell them that the King is too drunk to go to his own coronation!'

'You can say he's ill,' I said.

'Ill!' Sapt laughed angrily. 'Everybody will know what that means. He's been "ill" too many times before.'

'Tell me, do you think somebody put something in his wine?' I asked.

'It was Black Michael!' Fritz replied. 'We all know he wants to be King himself.'

For a moment or two we were all silent, and then Sapt looked at me, 'You must go to Strelsau and take his place!'

I stared at him. 'You're crazy, man! How can I do that? The King …'

'It's dangerous, I know,' said Sapt. 'But it's our only chance. If you don't go, Black Michael will be King and the real king will be dead or a prisoner.'

How could I refuse? It took me two minutes to decide.

'I'll go!' I said.

'Well done, boy!' cried Sapt. He went on quickly and quietly. 'After the coronation they'll take us to the palace for the night. When we're alone, you and I will leave and ride back here to fetch the King. He'll be all right by then. I'll take him back to Strelsau and you must get out of the country as fast as you can.'

'But what about the soldiers?' Fritz asked. 'They're Duke Michael's men, and they're coming to take the King back to Strelsau for the coronation.'

'We'll go before the soldiers get here,' Sapt said, 'and we'll hide the King.'



Sapt picked up the King in his arms.

He picked up the King in his arms and we opened the door. An old woman, Johann's mother, was standing there. She turned, without a word, and went back to the kitchen.

'Did she hear?' Fritz asked.

'Don't worry. I'll make sure she can't talk,' Sapt said, and he carried the King away.

When he returned, he told us that he had locked the old woman in a room underground. The King and Josef were hidden in another room underground. 'Josef will take care of the King and tell him everything when he wakes up. Come,' he went on, 'there's no time to lose. It's already six o'clock.'

Soon I was dressed in the King's clothes, the horses were ready and we were on our way. As we rode through the forest, Sapt told me everything that he could about my life, my family, my friends, and the things I liked or did not like. He told me what to do when we got there, and how to speak to different people. He was a wonderful teacher, and I listened hard. One mistake could mean death for all three of us.

It was eight o'clock when we arrived at the station and got on the train, and by half-past nine we were in Strelsau.

And when King Rudolf the Fifth stepped out of the train, the people shouted, 'God save the King!'

Old Sapt smiled, 'God save them both,' he said quietly. 'I only hope we are all alive tonight!'

4

My adventures begin

As we made our way to the palace, I began to feel that I really was the King of Ruritania, with Marshal Strakencz, the head of the army, on my right and old Sapt on my left. I could see that Strelsau was really two towns – the Old Town and the New Town. The people of the Old Town, who were poor, wanted Duke Michael to be their King, but the people of the New Town wanted King Rudolf. We went through the New Town first, and it was bright and colourful, with the ladies' dresses and the red roses of the Elphbergs. The people shouted loudly for their King as we passed through the streets. But when we came to the Old Town, the Marshal and Sapt moved nearer to my horse, and I could see that they were afraid for me.

'Stay back!' I called. 'I'll show my people that I'm not afraid of them.' Some of the crowd were pleased when they heard this, but most of them watched me in silence.

Finally, we reached the great church of Strelsau. I remember very little of the coronation – only two faces. One was a beautiful girl with wonderful red hair, the Princess Flavia. The other was the face of a man with black hair and dark, deep eyes – Black Michael. When he saw me, his face turned white. Clearly, he was surprised and deeply unhappy to see me.

The coronation seemed to last for hours, but I managed to say and do all the right things. At last it was over, and I was now the King of Ruritania! As Princess Flavia and I drove back to the palace in an open car, one man in the crowd called out, 'When's the wedding?'



I remember very little of the coronation.

The Princess's face went a little pink when she heard this.

After a while she said, 'You seem different today, Rudolf. Quieter and more serious. Are you going to become a more sensible person now?'

The Princess, I realized, did not think very highly of the King. As for me, I thought the King was a very lucky man.

'If that will please you, I'll try to do it,' I said softly.

The Princess's face went pink again. Then she said, 'You must be careful of Michael. You know—'

'I know,' I said, 'that he wants what I have, and also what I hope to have one day.' As I spoke, I looked at her, and she smiled at me prettily.

'I wonder what the King's doing now,' I thought.

*

The royal dinner went on for a long time, but at last Fritz, Sapt, and I were alone in the King's dressing-room.

'You did well,' Fritz said, 'but, Rassendyll, be careful! Black Michael looked blacker than ever today – because you and the Princess had so much to say to each other.'

'She's very beautiful,' I replied.

'Come on,' Sapt cried. 'There's no time for that now. We must leave for Zenda at once, to find the King! If we're caught, we'll all be killed! Black Michael has had a letter from Zenda, so perhaps he knows already. Don't unlock the door, Fritz, while we're away, or you'll be a dead man. Say the King must be left alone to rest. Now, come on. The horses are ready.'

Fritz and I shook hands, then I covered my red hair and most of my face. Sapt and I left the room by a secret door, and we found ourselves outside, at the back of the palace gardens.

A man was waiting there with two horses.

Soon we left the town behind us, and we were out in the country. We rode like the wind and by ten o'clock had come to the edge of the forest of Zenda.

Suddenly Sapt stopped. 'Listen!' he said quietly. 'Horses behind us! Quick! Get down! The castle's to the left,' he continued. 'Our road's to the right.'

We hid in the thick trees, and we waited and watched. The men came nearer. It was Black Michael and another man. When they came to the two roads, they stopped.



It was Black Michael and another man.

'Which way?' the Duke asked.

'To the castle!' the other man cried. 'They'll know there what's been happening.'

The Duke waited for a moment. 'To Zenda then!' he cried finally, and the two men took the road to the left.

We waited for ten more minutes, and then we hurried on.

When we arrived at the house in the forest, we ran to the underground rooms. The one where Sapt had locked up the old woman was empty. She had escaped! The other room was locked. Sapt's face was white with fear. Between us, we broke down the door and ran in. I found a light and looked round the room. The servant Josef was on the floor – dead! I held up the light and looked in every corner of the room.

'The King isn't here!' I said.

5

His Majesty returns to Strelsau

It was one o'clock in the morning. For a few minutes we said nothing. Then Sapt cried, 'The Duke's men have taken the King prisoner!'

'Then we must get back and wake everyone in Strelsau!' I cried. 'We must catch Black Michael before he kills the King.'

'Who knows where the King is now?' Sapt answered. Then suddenly he began to laugh. 'But we've given Black Michael a problem,' he said. 'Yes, my boy. We'll go back to Strelsau. The King will be in his palace in Strelsau again tomorrow.'

'No!' I cried.

'Yes!' Sapt answered. 'It's the only way to help him. Go back and take his place for him.'

'But the Duke knows …'

'Yes, but he can't speak, can he? What can he say? "This man isn't the King because I've taken the real King prisoner and murdered his servant." Can he say that?'

'But people will soon realize I'm not the real King,' I said.

'Perhaps, perhaps not,' said Sapt. 'But we must have a King in Strelsau, or Michael will ride in tomorrow as the new King! Listen, boy, if you don't go back to Strelsau, they'll kill the King. And if you *do* go back, they *can't* kill the King. Because if they kill him, how can they ever say that you're not the real King? Don't you see?' he cried. 'It's a dangerous game, but it gives us a chance of winning.'

It was a wild, hopeless plan, but I was young. I would never have the chance of an adventure like this again. 'Sapt, I'll try it,' I said.

'Good for you!' Sapt cried. 'But we must hurry! Look!'

He pulled me over to the door. The moon was low now, and there was not much light, but I could just see a small group of men on horses. They were Black Michael's men, probably coming to take the dead body of Josef away.

'We can't let them go without doing something,' I said, thinking of poor Josef.

'Right,' Sapt agreed. We ran out of the back of the house, and quickly got onto our horses. Silently, we waited in the darkness, and then we galloped round the house and straight into the group of men. Between us, we killed three of them, but a bullet hit my finger and it began to bleed.



We galloped straight into the group of men.

We rode hard all night and it was about eight or nine o'clock in the morning when we reached Strelsau. Luckily, the streets were still empty. We arrived at the palace, went in, and got to the dressing-room. When we opened the door, Fritz was asleep, but he woke immediately. When he saw me, he fell to the ground and cried, 'Thank God, Your Majesty! You're safe!'

'Well done, boy!' Sapt shouted. 'We'll do it!'

Fritz stood up. He looked at me, up and down, down and up. Then he took a step backwards. 'Where's the King?' he cried.

'Be quiet,' Sapt warned him. 'Someone will hear!'

Fritz's face was white now. 'Is the King dead?' he asked quietly.

'Please God, no,' I answered. 'But Black Michael has him.'

*

The next day was a long one for me. Sapt talked to me for three hours about what I must do and what I must say, what I liked and what I didn't like. Then I had to do some of the King's business, but, because of my damaged finger, I did not have to write my name on any papers.

When, at last, I was alone with Sapt and Fritz, we began to talk about Black Michael. Fritz told me that Black Michael had six very dangerous men among his servants – three Ruritanians, a Belgian, a Frenchman, and an Englishman. They did anything that the Duke ordered, and did not stop at murder. Three of them – the foreigners, Fritz had heard – were in Strelsau now with Duke Michael.

Sapt banged the table with his hand in excitement. 'Then the King must be alive! Michael's brought the foreigners with him, and left the three Ruritanians to hold the King prisoner. Usually, the Six, as they're called, go everywhere with him.'

Fritz wanted to do something immediately about Black Michael and his men, but Sapt and I realized that we could not do anything openly.

'We'll play a waiting game, and let Michael make the first move,' I said.

And so I continued as King of Ruritania. In order to help the real King, I tried to make myself popular with the people. I went riding through the streets, smiling and talking to everybody. I also went to visit the Princess Flavia. The King's officials had told me that the Princess was very popular, and the people hoped that she would become my wife.

It was easy for me to pretend to be in love with the Princess. Too easy. Those beautiful eyes and that lovely smile were stealing my heart. Here was my greatest danger! I was pretending to be another man, but losing my own heart. On my first visit, we sat together for a long time, talking of this and that. When I got up to leave, Princess Flavia said, 'Rudolf, you will be careful, won't you? You have enemies, as I'm sure you know, and your life is very important to … Ruritania.'



We sat together for a long time, talking of this and that.

'Only to Ruritania?' I asked softly.

'And to your loving cousin,' she answered quietly.

I could not speak. I took her hand in mine. Then, with a heavy heart, I left.

Of course, I made many mistakes in my new life as King. But I managed to talk my way out of them, with luck and with help from Fritz and Sapt. It was like living on a knife edge. Once I met my brother Michael in the Princess's house. We smiled and talked politely, but I could see the anger in his black eyes.

6

An adventure with a tea-table

One day Sapt brought me some news – he had found out where the King was. Duke Michael was holding him prisoner somewhere in the Castle of Zenda.

Sapt also brought me a letter. It was in a woman's handwriting.

'To know what you most wish to know,' the letter began, 'meet me tonight in the garden of the big house in New Avenue. Come at midnight, and come alone.'

There was another note on the back of the letter. 'Ask yourself which woman does not want Black Michael to marry the Princess. A. de M.'

'Antoinette de Mauban!' I cried. *'She* wants to marry the Duke.'

'That's true,' Sapt said. 'But you won't go, of course. They'll kill you! Duke Michael made her write this letter!'

'I must,' I replied. 'Every day we play this game there's more danger. I could make a mistake at any time, and, if I do, we'll all die. Don't you see? I have to go tonight. We can't go on much longer.'

'Then I'm coming too,' said Sapt.

So, at half-past eleven that night, Sapt and I rode out to the house in New Avenue. We left Fritz to watch my room in the palace. The night was dark, so I took a lamp. I also had my revolver and a knife.

We soon reached the house, and came to a gate in the wall. I got off my horse.

'I'll wait here,' said Sapt. 'If I hear anything, I'll—'

'Stay where you are!' I answered quickly. 'It's the King's only chance. They mustn't kill you too!'

'You're right,' said Sapt. 'Good luck!'

Silently, I opened the gate and went into the garden. In front of me I could see the dark shape of a summer-house and I moved towards it. Without a sound, I went up the steps, pushed open the door and went in. A woman hurried over to me and took me by the hand. I turned my lamp on her. She was beautiful.



Silently, I opened the gate and went into the garden.

'Close the door!' she said. 'We must be quick, Mr Rassendyll! Michael made me write the letter – three men are coming to kill you – three of the Six! They'll tell everyone that Sapt and Fritz von Tarlenheim murdered you. Then Michael will make himself King and marry the Princess.' Antoinette's beautiful eyes were sad as she added softly, 'I can't let him marry her. I love him!'

'But the King,' I said. 'I know he's in the Castle of Zenda – but where?'

'Go across the drawbridge and you come to a heavy door … Listen! What's that? They're coming! They're too soon! Put out your lamp!' she cried, her eyes filled with fear. 'Quickly! You must go. There's a ladder at the end of the garden, against the wall!'

But it was too late. The three men were already outside. There was a small hole in the door, and I put my eye to it. My hand was on my revolver. It was no good! There were three of them. I could kill one perhaps, but then …

A voice came from outside. 'Mr Rassendyll …' It was the Englishman. 'We only want to talk to you. Open the door.'

'We can talk through the door,' I replied. I looked through the hole again and saw that they were on the top step. When I opened the door, they would run at me.

'We'll let you go if you leave the country and we'll give you fifty thousand English pounds,' continued Detchard, the Englishman.

'Give me a minute to think,' I answered.

Wildly, I looked around the summer-house and saw a metal garden table and some chairs. I picked up the table and held it in front of me, by the legs. Then I went to the back of the room and waited.

‘All right, I agree,’ I called. ‘Open the door!’

I heard them arguing with each other, and then Detchard said to the Belgian, ‘Why, Bersonin, are you afraid of one man?’

A second later the door opened.



I held the table in front of me, by the legs.

De Gautet, the Frenchman, was with the other two, and the three men were standing there with their revolvers ready. With a shout, I ran at them as hard as I could. They tried to shoot me, but the bullets hit the table. The next second the table knocked them to the ground and we all fell on top of each other. Quickly, I picked myself up and ran for my life through the trees. I could hear them coming after me. Was Antoinette right? Was there really a ladder by the wall? I reached the end of the garden. The ladder was there! In a minute I was up it and over the wall.

Sapt was waiting with the horses and seconds later we were on our way home. And, as we rode, we laughed because I had fought Duke Michael’s dangerous men – with a tea-table!



In a minute I was up the ladder and over the wall.

7
For love of the King

Every day I was sent a secret report by the Chief of Police, and the next afternoon I was playing cards with Fritz when Sapt brought it in. We learned that Duke Michael and the Three had left Strelsau, and that Antoinette de Mauban had also left. Clearly, they had gone to Zenda. The report also said that the people were unhappy because the King had not yet asked Princess Flavia to marry him.

'Yes,' said Fritz. 'It's true. I've heard that the Princess loves the King and she's very sad …'

'Well,' Sapt informed us, 'I've arranged a dance at the royal palace this evening, for the Princess.'

'Why wasn't I told?' I asked angrily.

But Sapt continued, 'Everything is arranged. And tonight you must ask the Princess to marry you.'

'No! I'll do nothing to hurt her!' I cried.

'All right, my boy,' Sapt smiled gently. 'Just say something nice to her, then. Remember, she thinks you're the King and we don't want her to be angry with him, do we?'

I understood, of course. If the King was saved, then Flavia must marry him. If he was not saved, then Sapt would ask me to stay and marry the Princess. Duke Michael must not be King.

The dance was wonderful. Flavia was beautiful and I danced with her again and again. Everyone could feel our happiness. I forgot about the crowd of rich, colourful people who were watching us. I had eyes only for my beautiful Flavia.

When supper had finished, Fritz touched me on the shoulder. I stood up, took Flavia's hand and led her into a little room. They brought coffee to us and then the door was closed quietly. The Princess and I were alone.

The windows of the little room opened onto the garden. The night was fine and the room was filled with the sweet smell of the flowers outside. Flavia sat down and I stood opposite her. I was fighting with myself … But then she looked at me – and I was lost! I forgot the King, I forgot who I was, I forgot everything! I fell to my knees, took her gently in my arms and kissed her.



I took Flavia gently in my arms and kissed her.

Suddenly she pushed me away. ‘Is it true? Do you really love me?’ she cried. ‘Or is it because you’re the King and you must marry me?’

‘No!’ I answered quietly. ‘I love you more than my life!’

Flavia smiled. ‘Oh, why do I love you now?’ she said softly. ‘I didn’t love you before, but I do now.’

How happy I was! It was not the King she loved. It was me – it was Rudolf Rassendyll! But as I looked into her lovely face, I knew I could not live with the lie. How could I pretend to be the King any longer?

‘There’s something I must tell you …’ I began in a low voice.

‘Your Majesty,’ said a voice from the garden. ‘People are waiting to say goodbye.’

It was Sapt. He had heard me talking to the Princess.

‘We’ll come,’ I replied coldly.

But Flavia, her eyes full of her love for me, held out her hand to Sapt as he came into the room. He took it and said softly and sadly, ‘God save your Royal Highness.’ And then he added, ‘But before all comes the King – God save the King!’

When Sapt told the people that Princess Flavia had accepted the King as her future husband, they were wild with happiness.

‘You know, Sapt,’ I said sadly, ‘I could marry the Princess and let my people kill Duke Michael – and the King.’

‘I know,’ Sapt replied quietly.

‘So we must go to Zenda and bring the King home at once!’ I said.



'You're the finest Elphberg of them all,' said Sapt.

Sapt put his hand on my shoulder. 'You're the finest Elphberg of them all,' he said with feeling.

*

Before we left Strelsau, I saw the Marshal and asked him to stay near Flavia, to take care of her and to keep her safe from Duke Michael. Then I went to say goodbye to her. At first she was cold with me. She did not understand why I wanted to leave her. But her anger changed to fear when I told her that I was going after Duke Michael.

'Oh, Rudolf, be careful!' she cried. 'He's a dangerous man! Please come back safely to me.'

'Duke Michael can never keep me away from you,' I promised. But in my heart I knew that another man could.

8

Back to Zenda

The next day Sapt, Fritz, and I left Strelsau to go to Tarlenheim House. This fine modern house belonged to Fritz's uncle and was near the Castle of Zenda. We had ten brave young men with us. Sapt had told them that a friend of the King's was a prisoner in the Castle of Zenda and that the King needed their help.

Michael, of course, knew of my arrival. But I was sure he did not understand why I had come. He would think that my plan was to kill him *and* the King – and marry the Princess myself. So, I had not been in the house an hour when he sent three of the Six to me. These were not the three men who had tried to kill me. This time he sent the three Ruritanians – Lauengram, Krafstein and young Rupert of Hentzau.

'Duke Michael is very sorry that he can't welcome you himself,' explained Rupert of Hentzau. 'But, sadly, he's ill at the moment.'

'I hope that my dear brother will soon be better,' I replied with a smile.

Rupert threw back his head, shook his black hair and laughed. He was a good-looking young man. People said he had broken many hearts already.

'Oh, I'm sure he will!' he answered.

*



Rupert threw back his head and laughed.

That evening, instead of having dinner at the house, Fritz and I went to the little hotel in the town of Zenda where I had stayed before.

'Ask for a room where we can dine alone,' I said to Fritz. 'And ask the pretty girl to bring our food.'

I covered my face and the girl came and put the wine down on the table. When she

turned to go, she looked at me and I let her see my face.

'The King!' she cried. 'You were the King! Oh, I'm sorry, sir! I'm sorry! The things that we said!'

'Forget that now,' I answered. 'You can help me. Bring our dinner, but tell no one that the King is here.'

She came back in a few minutes, looking very serious.

'How's your friend Johann?' I began.

She looked surprised. 'Oh, we don't see him very often now,' she answered. 'He's very busy at the castle.'

'But you could get Johann to meet you tomorrow night, couldn't you? At ten o'clock, perhaps, on the road out of Zenda.'

'Yes, sir … You're not going to hurt him?'

'Not if he does what I say. Go now, and say nothing about this.'

After dinner, we left to go back to Tarlenheim House. We had almost reached it when we saw Sapt running to meet us. 'Have you seen them?' he cried.

'Who?' I asked.

'Duke Michael's men. Don't go out unless you have six men or more with you!' he said. 'You know Bernenstein, one of your men?'

'Of course,' I answered. 'A good, strong man, about as tall as me.'

'Well, they tried to kill him. He's upstairs now with a bullet in his arm. He was walking in the woods and he saw three men. Suddenly, they started shooting at him, so he began to run. He was lucky. They were afraid to come too near the house, so he escaped. But it was you they wanted to kill!'

'Sapt,' I said, 'I promise I'll do one thing for Ruritania before I leave it.'

'What's that?' asked Sapt.

'I'll kill every one of the Six. Ruritania will be a better place without them!'

9

News of the prisoner

The next morning I was sitting in the garden in the sun when suddenly I saw young Rupert of Hentzau on horseback coming through the trees towards me. He was not afraid of my men, but asked to speak with me alone. He said he had a message for me from the Duke of Strelsau. I asked my friends to move away, and Rupert came and sat down near me.

'Rassendyll,' he began, 'the Duke …'

'Don't you know how to speak to the King?' I asked.

'Why pretend with me?'

'Because it isn't finished yet.'

'Well, I'm here because I want to help you …'

'Then give me the message. What does the Duke want?' I asked.

'He wants you to leave. He'll take you safely out of the country and give you a hundred thousand pounds.'

'I refuse,' I replied immediately.

Rupert laughed. 'I knew it!' he cried. 'Duke Michael doesn't understand men like us! … You must die, then,' he added carelessly.

'Yes,' I answered. 'But you won't be alive to see me die!' I laughed. 'How's your prisoner?' I added.

'Alive,' he replied. 'How's the pretty Princess?'

I took a step towards him. 'Go now, before I kill you,' I shouted angrily.

Rupert turned, but suddenly he came back. He put out his right hand. 'Shake hands!' he called.

Of course, he knew what I would do. I put my hands behind my back. Quickly, his left hand moved towards me. In it he held a dagger and it was coming straight at my heart! I jumped to one side, and the dagger went deep into my shoulder. Before my friends could do anything, Rupert of Hentzau was on his horse and galloping through the trees. I heard my men going after him with their guns – and then everything went black.



The dagger went deep into my shoulder.

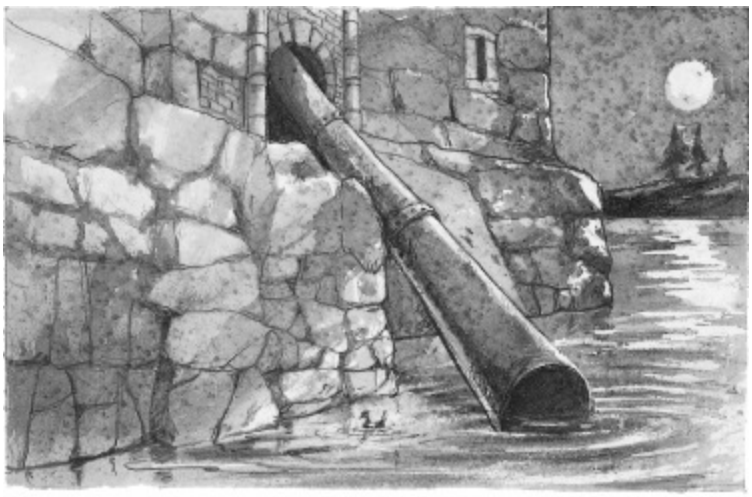
When I awoke it was dark, and Fritz was at my bedside. He told me that I was not badly hurt, and that the plan to catch Johann had been successful.

'He seems pleased to be here,' Fritz said. 'I think he's afraid of Duke Michael.'

Later Sapt brought Johann up to see me. At first Johann was afraid to speak, but then he began to talk. We asked him many questions, and finally Johann gave us the information we wanted.

In the Castle of Zenda, near the drawbridge and below the ground, there were two small rooms, cut out of the rock itself. In the first of these rooms there were always three of the Six. At the back of this room there was a door which led into the second room. The King was in the second room.

'If someone tries to get into the first room, two of the three men will fight, but Rupert of Hentzau or Detchard will run into the second room and kill the King,' Johann said. 'There's a small window in the second room with a large pipe going down into the moat outside,' he went on. 'You can get a man inside it, and they'll tie a heavy stone to the King's body and push it down the pipe. The body will go down and disappear under the water, and the murderers will then go down the pipe themselves, and swim across the moat.'



'There's a large pipe going down into the moat outside.'

‘And if I bring an army to the castle?’ I asked.

‘Duke Michael will still murder the King,’ replied Johann. ‘He won’t fight. He’ll kill the King and push his body down the pipe. And he’ll put one of the Six in the prison. He’ll say the man had done something to make him angry. That will stop the stories about a prisoner in Zenda.’ Johann stopped for a minute, but then he added, ‘If they know I’ve told you this, they’ll kill me. They’re all bad, but Rupert of Hentzau is the worst. Don’t let them kill me …’

‘All right,’ I said. ‘But if anyone asks you who the prisoner of Zenda is, don’t tell him. If you do, I’ll kill you myself!’

Johann left the room and I looked at Sapt.

‘It doesn’t matter what plan we make,’ I said. ‘The King will be dead before we can get to him!’

Sapt shook his grey head angrily. ‘You’ll still be King of Ruritania in a year’s time.’

‘Perhaps one of the Duke’s men will turn against him …’ I began.

‘Impossible,’ replied Sapt.

‘Then we need the help of God,’ I said.

10

A night outside the castle

I wanted Duke Michael to think that I was still very ill, so we told the newspapers that the King had had a very serious accident. When Princess Flavia read this, she was very worried and she decided to come and see me. The Marshal could not stop her, and, although I was afraid for her, I was excited at the thought of seeing her again. We spent two wonderfully happy days together.

We had sent Johann back to the Castle of Zenda and suddenly we had a message from him. The real King was very ill.

'I must save him,' I said to myself. 'I love Flavia more each day. I can't go on like this much longer.'

I talked to Sapt. He agreed, so we made our plans.

*

Late the next night, Sapt, Fritz, and I, with six more men, rode out towards the Castle of Zenda. Sapt was carrying a long rope and I had a short, thick stick and a long knife.

The night was dark, and it was wet and windy. We stayed away from the town and we met no one. When we came to the moat, we stopped near some trees and the six men hid there with the horses. Then Sapt tied the rope round one of the trees near the water. I pulled off my boots, put the stick between my teeth and gently went down the rope into the water. I was going to take a look at the pipe.



I went down the rope into the water.

It had been warm and bright that day, and the water was not cold. Slowly and carefully I swam round the dark walls of the castle. There were lights in the new buildings, and from time to time I heard people shouting and laughing. 'That must be young Rupert and his friends,' I thought. Suddenly a dark shape appeared in front of me. It was the pipe! The bottom of it was very wide and came out into the moat. And then I saw something which nearly made my heart stop. It was a boat, and in the boat there was a man! His gun was beside him, but, luckily, he was asleep. As quietly as I could, I moved closer.

The man still slept. What could I do? I had to save the King. I took out my knife and drove it through the sleeping man's heart! On the other side of the castle they were still singing.

I had very little time. Someone could come at any minute. I looked up at where the pipe went through the wall into the prison. There was a thin line of light at the bottom edge. I heard Detchard's voice, and then I heard the King reply. Just then the light went out, and, in the darkness, I heard the King crying. I did not call to him. I had to get away safely – and take the body of the dead watchman with me.

I climbed into the boat and began to go back to where my friends were. No one could hear me because the wind was strong. But from somewhere behind me, I heard a shout. Someone was calling to the watchman. I reached the side of the moat where Sapt and Fritz were waiting. Quickly, I tied the rope round the man's body and Sapt and Fritz pulled it up. Then I climbed up the rope myself.

'Call our men from the trees,' I said quietly. 'And hurry!'

But just then, three men rode round from the front of the castle. Luckily, they did not see us, but they heard our six friends riding out of the trees, and with a shout they galloped towards them.

Seconds later we heard the sound of shots and I ran to help our men. Sapt and Fritz followed.

'Kill them!' cried a voice. It was Rupert of Hentzau.

'Too late! They've got both of us!' cried another voice. 'Save yourself, Rupert!'

I ran on, holding my stick in my hand. Suddenly, through the darkness, I saw a horse coming towards me. I jumped at the horse's head, and saw the man's face above me.



I jumped at the horse's head, and saw the man's face above me.

'At last!' I shouted. 'Rupert of Hentzau!'

He had only his sword, and my men were coming at him from one side, and Sapt and Fritz from the other.

Rupert laughed. 'It's the play-actor!' he cried, and with his sword he knocked my stick from my hand. Then he turned his horse, galloped to the moat, and jumped into the water with our bullets flying round his ears. Our men tried to shoot him in the water, but it was dark, there was no moon – and we lost him.

We had killed two of the Six – Lauengram and Krafstein – but I was angry. Three of our brave friends were also dead, and we carried them home with a heavy heart.

And I did not like to hear Rupert call me a play-actor.

*

Of course, Michael and I could not let the people know that we were enemies. So, in the daytime it was safe to be in the town of Zenda. One day, soon after our night outside the castle, Princess Flavia and I were riding through the town when we saw a group of people dressed in black going to the church. Rupert of Hentzau was with them, and when he saw us, he turned his horse and came towards us.

'It's the funeral of my dear friend, Lauengram,' he said, in answer to our question.

'I'm sorry your friend is dead,' I said to him.

'And I'm sorry, too,' Flavia added, her beautiful blue eyes sad.

Rupert looked at her and smiled. Then he turned and rode away. Although I was angry because he had smiled at Flavia, I went after him.

'You fought bravely the other night,' I said, 'and you're young. Help me save the King – and I'll help you.'

But Rupert was not interested. ‘No,’ he answered. ‘But if they were both dead – the King and the Duke – then you could be King and marry your Princess, and I could be rich, and have the woman I want.’



‘And I could be rich,’ said Rupert, ‘and have the woman I want.’

‘Antoinette de Mauban?’ I asked carelessly, trying not to show my interest.

‘Yes,’ replied Rupert. ‘I hate the Duke. She loves him, not me!’ Angrily, he joined the funeral group again.

Strangely, when we returned home there was a message for me from Antoinette herself.

‘I helped you once. Help me now. Save me from this terrible place! Save me from these murderers!’

I was sorry for her, but what could I do?

11

A dangerous plan

One day Johann came to tell us that the King was now very sick, and that Antoinette de Mauban and a doctor were looking after him. But the Duke never left Rupert of Hentzau alone with Antoinette. I understood why, after what Rupert had told me. There were often angry voices in the castle these days, Johann told us.

Two of the Six were now dead, but there were always two men watching the King. The other two slept in a room above and would hear them if they called. Detchard and Bersonin watched by night; Rupert of Hentzau and De Gautet by day. The Duke's rooms were on the first floor, in the new buildings of the castle, and Antoinette's room was on the same floor. But at night the Duke locked the door of her room, and pulled up the drawbridge. He kept the key himself. Johann slept near the front door of the new castle with five other men – but they had no guns.

We could not wait any longer. 'Listen!' I said to Johann. 'I'll make you rich if you do what I say.' Johann agreed.

'You must take this note to Madame de Mauban,' I said, 'and tomorrow, at two o'clock in the morning, you must open the front door of the new castle. Tell the others that you need air, or something – and then escape.'

Johann was clearly afraid, but he seemed to understand. I explained my plan to Sapt and Fritz.

'When Johann opens the front door,' I said, 'Sapt and his men will run into the castle and hold the men who are sleeping there. At the same time Antoinette will scream loudly again and again. She'll cry "Help! Help me, Michael!" And she'll shout Rupert of Hentzau's name. Duke Michael will hear and he'll run out of his room – straight into the hands of Sapt! Sapt will get the key from the Duke and let down the drawbridge. Rupert and De Gautet will hear the noise and hurry to cross the drawbridge. I'll hide by the bridge, in the moat, and when they try to cross, I'll kill them. Then we'll hurry to the room where the King is, and kill Detchard and Bersonin before they have time to kill the King.'

The others listened in silence. It was a very dangerous plan, and I did not really think it would work – but we had to try!

That evening I went to visit Flavia. She seemed very thoughtful, and as I was leaving, she placed a ring on my finger. I was wearing the King's ring, but I took off my Rassendyll family ring and gave it to her. 'Wear this for me always,' I said.

She kissed the ring, and replied seriously, 'I'll wear it until the day I die.'

And then I had to leave her. I had already told the Marshal that if anything happened to

the King, he must take Flavia to Strelsau, tell the people that Duke Michael had killed the King – and that Flavia was their Queen. I knew this could be my last day alive.



'Wear this for me always.'

12

The prisoner and the King

We needed bad weather, but it was a fine, clear night. At midnight Sapt, Fritz, and their men left and rode quietly through the woods towards the castle. If everything went well, they would get there at a quarter to two and wait for Johann to open the front door. If Johann did not open the door, Fritz would come round to the other side of the castle to find me. If I was not there, then I was dead – and the King, too! Sapt and his men would go back to Tarlenheim House and return with the Marshal and more men to get into the castle.

So, half an hour later, I, too, left Tarlenheim. I took a shorter way than Sapt and when I reached the moat, I hid my horse in the trees, tied my rope round a strong tree and let myself down into the water. Slowly, I began to swim along under the castle walls. Just after a quarter to one, I came to the pipe and waited quietly in its shadow. Light was coming from Duke Michael's window opposite me across the moat, and I could see into the room. The next window along, which Johann had said was Antoinette's room, was dark.

Then the Duke's window opened, and Antoinette de Mauban looked out. Behind her there was a man. Rupert of Hentzau! What was he doing in the Duke's room? I wondered.

Rupert tried to put his arm round Antoinette, but she moved quickly away. At that moment, I heard the door of the room open and then the angry voice of Duke Michael.

'What are you doing here?' he cried.

'Waiting for you, sir,' Rupert replied quickly. 'I couldn't leave the lady alone.'

'Well, now you can go to bed. Are Detchard and Bersonin watching the prisoner?'

'Yes, sir.'

A few minutes later, Rupert crossed the drawbridge and it was pulled up. The light in Duke Michael's room went out, but a light came on, and stayed on, in Antoinette's room. In the silent darkness, I waited.

For about ten minutes everything was quiet, but suddenly I heard a noise on my side of the moat. A dark shape appeared in the gateway to the bridge, then turned and began to climb down some hidden steps in the wall. It was Rupert of Hentzau again – with a sword! Silently, he went down into the water and swam across the moat. Then he climbed out, and I heard him unlock the door. It was clear that Rupert of Hentzau had his own secret plans for that night.



It was Rupert of Hentzau again – with a sword!

It was not yet time for Johann to open the front door for my friends, and I still had to wait. I climbed up to the gateway of the bridge and hid in a dark corner. Now no one could enter or leave the old castle without fighting me. I wondered what Rupert was doing now, and a few seconds later I found out.

There was a sudden crash, and then a woman's screams rang through the night.

'Help me, Michael! Rupert of Hentzau!'

Those were the words that I had written for Antoinette! But these were screams of real fear and soon I heard shouts and the sound of fighting from Antoinette's room. Then Rupert appeared at the window. His back was towards me, but he was fighting. 'That's for you, Johann,' I heard him cry. Then, 'Come on, Michael!'

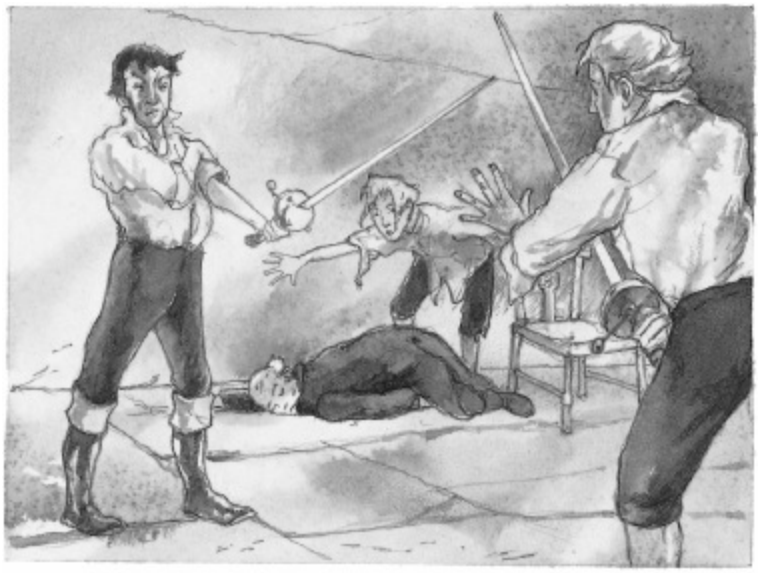
So Johann was in there too, fighting at the Duke's side! How could he open the door for Sapt now?

More of the Duke's men had run to the room and the noise of the fighting grew louder. Suddenly, Rupert gave a wild laugh, and with his sword in his hand, jumped from the window into the moat below.

At that moment the door of the old castle opened and De Gautet appeared beside me. I jumped at him with my sword, and a second later he fell dead in the doorway without a word or a sound.

Wildly, I searched his body for the keys. I found them, and in a minute I was in the first room, where Bersonin and Detchard were. But there was only Bersonin in the room. Before he had time to realize that I was there, I had killed him. Detchard had run into the King's room and locked the door behind him. I ran at it to break it down. But would I be in time? Was the King already dead?

The King was standing helplessly by the wall. But the doctor was also in the room and the brave little man had thrown himself at Detchard. He gave his life for the King, because, as I entered, Detchard pulled himself free and drove his sword into the doctor's side. Then, with an angry shout, Detchard turned to me.



With an angry shout, Detchard turned to me.

We fought long and hard. Detchard was an excellent swordsman, and I was growing tired. He drove me back against the wall, gave me a deep cut in the arm, and began to smile. In a second he would kill me.

Suddenly, the King realized who I was.

'Cousin Rudolf!' he cried. Then he picked up a chair and threw it at Detchard's legs. The Englishman, jumping to one side, turned his sword against the King, and with a cry the King fell to the ground. Detchard moved towards me again, stepped in the doctor's blood on the floor – and fell to the ground himself. I had him! A second later his body lay across the dead doctor.

But was the King dead? I had no time to find out, because just then I heard the noise of the drawbridge coming down. And that wild-cat Rupert of Hentzau was still alive. The King must wait for help while I fought his enemies. I ran out of the room and up the steps towards the drawbridge. And then I heard the sound of laughter – Rupert of Hentzau was laughing!

He was standing alone in the middle of the bridge. In the gateway on the far side stood a group of the Duke's men. They seemed too frightened to move.

'Come out, Michael, you dog!' Rupert shouted.

But a woman's wild cry answered him. 'He's dead! He's dead!'

The men in the gateway moved to one side and a woman came forward. Her face was as white as her long dress, and her dark hair lay over her shoulders. In her hand she held a gun. The shot rang out, but she missed. Rupert laughed. Again Antoinette de Mauban faced him, her gun ready. But, before she could shoot, Rupert jumped over the side of the bridge, and down into the moat below.



Again, Antoinette de Mauban faced Rupert, her gun ready.

At that moment I heard the sound of running feet inside the new castle – and the welcome voice of my old friend, Captain Sapt! Then I knew that the King was safe and needed me no more. I ran out on to the bridge and jumped down into the moat. I had business to finish with Rupert of Hentzau.

*

I swam hard and caught up with him round the corner of the old castle. He had found my rope, climbed out of the moat, and was already running towards the trees where I had left my horse.

I ran after him as fast as I could. He turned and saw me, and called out, laughing, 'Why, it's the play-actor!' But then, with a cry of surprise, he found my horse, and in a minute he was on its back.

'Get down!' I shouted. 'Stand and fight, like a man!'

He turned, waiting for me, and I ran at him with my sword. For a few minutes we fought wildly. Blood ran from his face where I had cut it, but I had fought too many fights that night. He would surely kill me now.

I was saved by Fritz, who came galloping round the castle to find me. When Rupert saw him coming, he knew he had no chance.

'Goodbye, Rudolf Rassendyll!' he called. 'We'll meet again!'

And he rode away into the forest, laughing and singing … and still alive.

I fell to the ground. Blood was running again from the cut in my arm, and I could not stand. Fritz jumped down from his horse and lifted me in his arms.



And Rupert rode away into the forest, laughing and singing.

‘Dear friend!’ he said. ‘Thank God I’ve found you! When Johann did not come, we had to break down the castle door. We were afraid we would be too late.’

‘And the King …?’ I said.

‘Thanks to a very brave Englishman,’ Fritz said gently, ‘the King is alive.’

13

Goodbye to Ruritania

Old Sapt worked hard to keep our secret hidden. He sent messages, told lies, and gave orders. All his plans were successful, except one. Nothing can stop a woman in love.



'No!' cried Sapt. 'He is the man you love – but he is not the King!'

When Princess Flavia heard that the King was hurt, she refused to stay at Tarlenheim House and rode at once to the Castle of Zenda. Sapt had hidden me in a room in the old castle, and he and Fritz brought her to me there. How happy she was to see me! She threw her arms round my neck and kissed me.

'No!' cried Sapt. 'It's not the King. Don't kiss him. He is the man you love – but he is not the King!'

Flavia's face went white. 'What do you mean?' she cried. She turned to me again. 'Rudolf! Why do you let them say these things?'

I looked deeply into her eyes.

'It's true,' I said quietly. 'I am not the King.'

For a minute she continued to hold on to me. She looked at Sapt, at Fritz, and finally at me again. Then, slowly, she fell forward and I laid her gently on the ground.

'I wish that Rupert had killed me,' I said.

*

I saw the King once more. He thanked me, and I gave him back the royal Elphberg ring. If he noticed Flavia's ring on my finger, he said nothing. We both knew that we would never meet again.

Before I left Ruritania, Princess Flavia asked to see me again, and Fritz took me to her. They had told her everything.

We had so much to say – and so little to say. A princess is not free to choose who to love.

'Flavia,' I said, 'I love you. I'll love you until the day I die.'

As I walked away, I heard her say my name again and again. 'Rudolf … Rudolf …' I can hear it now.

*

I live quietly now, but every year Fritz and I meet in a little town outside Ruritania. There, he gives me news of the Queen of Ruritania, the wife of King Rudolf the Fifth. And every year he brings me a red rose and a note with the words written: *Rudolf – Flavia – Always.* And I send her a red rose with the same message.

Shall I ever see her again? Who knows?



GLOSSARY

behave to do things well or badly

coronation when someone is made a king or a queen

cousin the son or daughter of your aunt or uncle

dagger a sharp knife used for fighting

drawbridge a bridge across the moat of a castle, that can be pulled up to stop people crossing

duke a title for an important nobleman

funeral when a dead person is put under the ground or is burned

Good heavens! an expression to show great surprise

Highness a word used when speaking to someone from a royal family *(Your Royal Highness)*

kiss *(v)* to touch someone with your lips in a loving way

ladder two long pieces of wood with steps between them, used for climbing up something

lead *(v)* to walk in front of someone to show them the way

lord a title for a nobleman (less important than a duke)

Majesty a word used when speaking to a king *(Your Majesty)*, or about a king *(His Majesty)*

Marshal a very important army officer

moat a deep wide ditch around a castle, filled with water

rescue *(v)* to save someone from danger

revolver a small gun, held in the hand

rope very strong, thick string

royal of a king or queen, or their family

servant someone who is paid to work in another person's house

shoulder the top of the arm where it joins the body

sword a long sharp knife (about a metre long), used for fighting

wine an alcoholic drink made from grapes

The Prisoner of Zenda

ACTIVITIES

ACTIVITIES

Before Reading

1 Read the story introduction on the first page of the book, and the back cover. What do you know now about Rudolf Rassendyll? Answer these questions about him.

Who does Rudolf Rassendyll…

1 look like?

2 make friends with?

3 try to rescue?

4 fight against?

5 fall in love with?

2 How much can you guess about this story? Choose words to complete this passage.

The story happens in Ruritania, which *is / is not* a real place, and is both an *adventure / animal* story and a *crime / love* story. There will be a lot of *ghosts / fighting* in the Castle of Zenda, and in the end the King's *enemies / friends* will *rescue / kill* him. The story will end *happily / sadly* for the King, but *happily / sadly* for Rudolf Rassendyll.

3 On the back cover of the book are these two questions. Can you guess the answers?

1 Who will rescue the King from his enemies?

2 Who will win the heart of the beautiful Princess Flavia?

ACTIVITIES

While Reading

Read Chapters 1 to 3. Who were these sentences said or written about?

1 'I know he can't do much about his hair, or his nose.'
2 The boy grew into a man with blue eyes, a long straight nose, and dark red hair.
3 'She's travelling on the same train as you, but don't fall in love with her.'
4 'He's only the second son and will never be king himself.'
5 'Friends who want the same place and the same wife.'
6 'Good heavens! He looks just like the King!'
7 'We've been trying to wake him for half an hour, but he's sleeping like a dead man.'
8 'God save them both.'

Read Chapters 4 to 6. Choose the best question-word for these questions, and then answer them.

How / What / When / Where / Who / Whose / Why

1 … faces did Rudolf remember from the coronation?
2 … did Rudolf and Sapt discover on their return to Zenda?
3 … did they go after the fight with the Duke's men?
4 … were the Six?
5 … did Rudolf feel about the Princess Flavia?
6 … did Antoinette de Mauban want to help Rudolf?
7 … did a tea-table help to save Rudolf's life?

Before you read Chapters 7, 8, and 9, can you guess what happens? Choose Y (yes) or N (no) for each of these ideas.

1 Rudolf asks Princess Flavia to marry him. Y/N
2 Rudolf tells the Princess who he really is. Y/N
3 Rudolf decides to kill the King and marry Flavia. Y/N
4 Duke Michael offers Rudolf a hundred thousand pounds to leave the country. Y/N

Read Chapters 7 to 9. Who said this, and to whom? Why did they say it? Match the sentences to the explanations below.

1 ‘I didn’t love you before, but I do now.’
2 ‘You’re the finest Elphberg of them all.’
3 ‘Don’t go out unless you have six men or more with you!’
4 ‘Duke Michael doesn’t understand men like us!’
5 ‘You’ll still be King of Ruritania in a year’s time.’

6 He thought Rudolf was a brave man, and a true gentleman.
7 He saw that he and Rudolf were the same, because they both loved adventure more than money.
8 She did not realize that he was not the same man.
9 He could not see any way of rescuing the real King.
10 He wanted to warn Rudolf that his life was in danger.

Read Chapters 10 and 11, then match these halves of sentences.

1 Rudolf swam around the castle to find the pipe …
2 Rudolf and his friends killed two of the Six that night, …
3 Rupert wanted Antoinette and hated Duke Michael, …
4 The plan was for Johann to take a note to Antoinette, …
5 At the same time, Johann would open the front door …
6 Rudolf would hide in the moat by the drawbridge, …
7 Before he left, Rudolf gave Flavia his family ring, …
8 telling her to scream for Duke Michael’s help in the night.
9 and she promised to wear it for ever.
10 because Antoinette loved the Duke, and not him.
11 which went from the prisoner’s room down into the moat.
12 and then enter the old castle and save the King.
13 but they also lost three of their own men.
14 in order to let Sapt and Fritz into the new castle.

Before you read Chapter 12, can you guess what will happen?

1 Will everything happen as Rudolf has planned?
2 Will Rudolf kill all of the Six, as he had promised?
3 Will Duke Michael die? If so, how?
4 Will Rudolf marry Flavia?

Read Chapters 12 and 13. Here are some untrue sentences about them. Rewrite them with the correct information.

1 When Antoinette screamed, there was no one in her room.

2 Johann did not come, so Sapt and Fritz could not get in through the castle door.

3 Duke Michael killed Antoinette, so Rupert of Hentzau tried to shoot the Duke.

4 Rudolf killed the other four of the Six.

5 Rudolf and Rupert fought wildly, and Rupert was killed.

6 Flavia married Rudolf Rassendyll, and forgot the King.

ACTIVITIES

After Reading

1 Who was who in this story? Complete the sentences with the right names. Then rewrite the sentences as a paragraph about each person, using pronouns (*he, she*, etc.) and linking words (*and, but, who, so, because*, etc.) where possible.

Duke Michael / Princess Flavia / Antoinette de Mauban / Rudolf Rassendyll / Rupert of Hentzau

1 ____was a young Ruritanian nobleman.
2 ____was a beautiful French lady.
3 ____was a young English nobleman.
4 ____was the King's beautiful cousin.
5 ____was the King's half-brother.
6 ____had the Elphberg hair and nose.
7 ____was a wild and dangerous fighter.
8 ____loved Duke Michael.
9 ____wanted to be the King and to marry Flavia.
10 ____fell in love with Rudolf Rassendyll.
11 ____tried to kill Rudolf Rassendyll several times.
12 ____looked just like the King.
13 ____kept the King a prisoner in the Castle of Zenda.
14 ____knew she could not marry Rudolf Rassendyll.
15 ____didn't want Duke Michael to become king and marry Flavia.
16 ____was one of Duke Michael's men.
17 ____agreed to take the King's place.
18 ____planned to kill the King if anyone tried to rescue him.
19 ____had to marry the King.
20 ____killed the Duke in a fight about Antoinette.
21 ____tried to help Rudolf Rassendyll rescue the King.
22 ____wanted the chance of a great adventure.
23 ____was killed by one of his own men in the end.

2 There are 15 words from the story hidden in this word search. Find the words,

and draw lines through them. (The words go from left to right, and from top to bottom.)

H	D	A	G	G	E	R	E	D	L	L
K	P	S	W	I	M	R	M	R	C	A
N	C	E	M	I	C	O	H	A	O	D
I	A	M	O	A	T	P	A	W	U	D
F	S	E	L	R	U	E	P	B	S	E
E	T	K	I	S	S	E	R	R	I	R
T	L	O	W	I	N	E	F	I	N	R
H	E	E	S	W	O	R	D	D	N	I
R	E	V	O	L	V	E	R	G	T	N
Z	A	P	R	I	S	O	N	E	U	G

Now write down all the letters that don't have lines through them. Begin with the first line and go across each line to the end. You will have 28 letters, which will make 6 words.

1 What are the words?

2 Who told which person to say these words, and why?

3 Why was Rudolf surprised when he heard them?

3 What did Sapt tell Princess Flavia about Rudolf at the end of the story? Put their conversation in the right order, and write in the speakers' names. Sapt speaks first (number 6).

1 ____'Yes, we think he had. So Rassendyll took the King's place at the coronation, and we planned to bring the King back to Strelsau that night.'

2 ____'His name, your Highness, is Rudolf Rassendyll.'

3 ____'Gone? Gone where?'

4 ____'I'll explain. On coronation day the King lay in Zenda like a dead man, after he had drunk a bottle of Duke Michael's wine the night before.'

5 ____'But you didn't bring him back.'

6 ____'It's true, your Highness. He is not the King. He is an Englishman, a visitor to our country.'

7 ____'And is the King still a prisoner?'

8 ____'No, your Highness, we didn't. When we returned to Zenda at midnight, the King had gone.'

9 ____'Brave … and kind and loving. Oh Sapt! How can I live without him?'

10 ____'No, his Majesty is now free, and his enemies are dead – thanks to a brave young Englishman.'

11 ____'Ah, the Rassendyll family … of course. But I still don't understand. Why did he pretend to be the King?'

12 ____'Duke Michael had taken him to the Castle of Zenda, as his prisoner.'

13 ____'Duke Michael had put something in the wine?'

14 ____'An Englishman? How can that be? He has the red hair, the Elphberg nose … Sapt, who is he?'

4 Perhaps this is what some of the people in the story were thinking. Who were they, and where were they at the time? Complete their thoughts in your own words. (Use as many words as you like.)

1 'I don't believe this! Here he is, walking into the church, when he should be still asleep. Didn't_____?'

2 'Everyone's watching us as we dance, but I don't care. When he looks into my eyes like that, I_____.'

3 'He's playing the lover very well, but – Good heavens! He's going to tell her who he really is! I_____!'

4 'I knew he'd refuse the money. But my dagger nearly got him. And now I must ride hard – his men_____.'

5 'He's killed the only man I loved! And he's just standing there, laughing at me. I'm_____!'

6 'I'm still worried about him. Since his walking holiday in Austria he's been so quiet, so sad. Perhaps_____.'

7 'It's been five years now. The same rose, the same message – and he can't wait to see them. Will_____?'

5 Here are some different endings for the story. Which do you prefer, or do you like the ending in the book best? Why?

- Flavia decides not to marry the King. She marries Rudolf, and goes to live quietly with him in England.
- After Rupert of Hentzau escapes from Antoinette's room, he runs back to the old castle and kills the King before Rudolf can stop him. Rudolf becomes King of Ruritania.
- Ten years later the King dies. Rudolf Rassendyll returns to Ruritania and marries Flavia.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Anthony Hope is the pen-name of Sir Anthony Hope Hawkins. He was born in London in 1863, and studied at Marlborough School, and then Balliol College, Oxford. At Oxford he was President of the Union, and he received a first-class degree. In 1887 Hope began work as a lawyer. He wrote stories in his free time, and in 1890 he published his first novel, *A Man of Mark*. Then one day in November 1893 he was walking back from work, when the idea of 'Ruritania' came into his head. The next day he wrote the first chapter of *The Prisoner of Zenda*, and one month later the story was finished. The book appeared in April 1894, and was an immediate success. Hope then became a full-time writer, publishing many popular novels, plays, and short stories. His second Ruritanian novel, *Rupert of Hentzau* (1898), follows the continuing adventures of Rudolf Rassendyll. Anthony Hope died in 1933.

The Prisoner of Zenda has appeared in many languages, and found success in many different countries. There have been a number of theatre versions of the story, and at least five films. The finest of these is probably David O. Selznik's 1937 film, starring Ronald Colman and Douglas Fairbanks. The story is as popular today as it was a hundred years ago, and is still one of the world's best-loved adventure stories.

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STARTER • 250 HEADWORDS

present simple – present continuous – imperative –
can/cannot, must – *going to* (future) – simple gerunds …

Her phone is ringing – but where is it?

Sally gets out of bed and looks in her bag. No phone. She looks under the bed. No phone. Then she looks behind the door. There is her phone. Sally picks up her phone and answers it. ***Sally's Phone***

… past simple – coordination with *and, but, or* –
subordination with *before, after, when, because, so*…

I knew him in Persia. He was a famous builder and I worked with him there. For a time I was his friend, but not for long. When he came to Paris, I came after him – I wanted to watch him. He was a very clever, very dangerous man. ***The Phantom of the Opera***

… present perfect – *will* (future) – *(don't) have to, must not, could* –
comparison of adjectives – simple *if* clauses – past continuous –
tag questions – *ask/tell* + infinitive …

While I was writing these words in my diary, I decided what to do. I must try to escape. I shall try to get down the wall outside. The window is high above the ground, but I have to try. I shall take some of the gold with me – if I escape, perhaps it will be helpful later.
Dracula

… *should, may* – present perfect continuous – *used to* – past perfect – causative – relative clauses – indirect statements …

Of course, it was most important that no one should see Colin, Mary, or Dickon entering the secret garden. So Colin gave orders to the gardeners that they must all keep away from that part of the garden in future. ***The Secret Garden***

… past perfect continuous – passive (simple forms) –
would conditional clauses – indirect questions –
relatives with *where/when* – gerunds after prepositions/phrases …

I was glad. Now Hyde could not show his face to the world again. If he did, every honest man in London would be proud to report him to the police. ***Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde***

… future continuous – future perfect –
passive (modals, continuous forms) –
would have conditional clauses – modals + perfect infinitive …

If he had spoken Estella's name, I would have hit him. I was so angry with him, and so depressed about my future, that I could not eat the breakfast. Instead I went straight to the old house. ***Great Expectations***

… passive (infinitives, gerunds) – advanced modal meanings –
clauses of concession, condition

When I stepped up to the piano, I was confident. It was as if I knew that the prodigy side of me really did exist. And when I started to play, I was so caught up in how lovely I looked that I didn't worry how I would sound. ***The Joy Luck Club***

BOOKWORMS • THRILLER & ADVENTURE • STAGE 3

Wyatt's Hurricane

DESMOND BAGLEY

Retold by Jennifer Bassett

Hurricane Mabel is far out in the Atlantic Ocean and moving slowly northwards. Perhaps it will never come near land at all. But if it hits the island of San Fernandez, many thousands of people will die. There could be winds of more than 250 kilometres an hour. There could be a huge tidal wave from the sea, which will drown the capital city of St Pierre. Mabel will destroy houses, farms, roads, bridges …

Only one man, David Wyatt, believes that Mabel will hit San Fernandez, but nobody will listen to him …

BOOKWORMS • FANTASY & HORROR • STAGE 3

The Star Zoo

HARRY GILBERT

In our world today a hummingbird is a small, brilliantly coloured bird that lives in the tall trees of tropical forests.

In the far distant future, Hummingbird (Hummy for short) is a girl of sixteen who lives somewhere in the Galaxy, on a planet called Just Like Home. She has the name 'Hummingbird' in big letters on all her clothes, but she has never seen a real hummingbird. She has never seen any living animal or bird at all. The Book of Remembering says that there were once many animals on a planet called Earth, but that was before the Burning, a long, long time ago …

The Prisoner of Zenda



'We must leave for Zenda at once, to find the King!' cried Sapt. 'If we're caught, we'll all be killed!'

So Rudolf Rassendyll and Sapt gallop through the night to find the King of Ruritania. But the King is now a prisoner in the Castle of Zenda. Who will rescue him from his enemies, the dangerous Duke Michael and Rupert of Hentzau?

And who will win the heart of the beautiful Princess Flavia?
(Word count 10,710)

- STAGE 6
- STAGE 5
- STAGE 4
- STAGE 3
- STAGE 2
- STAGE 1
- STARTERS

THRILLER & ADVENTURE

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3 OXFORD BOOKWORMS

Chương 1 - Gia tộc Rassendyll - và Elphberg

"Tôi tự hỏi bao giờ thì cậu sẽ làm được điều gì hữu ích, Rudolf," chị dâu của tôi, Rose, nói. Chị ấy nhìn tôi với vẻ cáu kỉnh qua bàn ăn sáng.
"Nhưng tại sao tôi phải làm gì, Rose?" Tôi đáp, bình tĩnh ăn quả trứng của mình.
"Tôi có gần đủ tiền để mua những thứ tôi muốn, và anh trai tôi, Robert, là một lãnh chúa - Lãnh chúa Burlesdon. Tôi rất hài lòng."
"Cậu đã hai mươi chín tuổi, và cậu chưa làm được gì ngoài..."
"Chơi bời? Đúng vậy. Chúng tôi, gia tộc Rassendyll, là một dòng họ giàu có và danh tiếng, chúng tôi không cần phải làm gì cả."
"Chúng tôi, gia tộc Rassendyll, không cần phải làm gì," tôi nói.

Điều này khiến Rose tức giận. **"Những gia đình giàu có và danh tiếng thường cư xử tệ hơn những gia đình ít quan trọng hơn,"** chị ấy nói.

Khi nghe điều này, tôi chạm vào mái tóc đỏ sẫm của mình. Tôi biết ý chị ấy là gì.
"Tôi rất vui vì tóc của Robert màu đen!" chị ấy kêu lên.

Đúng lúc đó, anh trai tôi, Robert, bước vào. Khi nhìn Rose, anh ấy nhận ra có điều gì đó không ổn.
"Có chuyện gì vậy, em yêu?" anh ấy hỏi.
"Ồ, chị ấy tức giận vì tôi chẳng bao giờ làm gì hữu ích, và vì tôi có mái tóc đỏ," tôi nói.
"Chà, tôi biết cậu ấy không thể làm gì với mái tóc hay cái mũi của mình..." Rose bắt đầu.
"Không, cái mũi và mái tóc là đặc điểm của gia đình," anh trai tôi đồng ý. **"Và Rudolf có cả hai."**

Trong phòng có nhiều bức tranh gia đình, và một trong số đó là bức chân dung của một người phụ nữ rất xinh đẹp, Quý bà Amelia, sống cách đây một trăm năm mươi năm. Tôi đứng dậy và quay lại nhìn bức tranh.
"Nếu anh mang bức tranh đó đi, Robert," Rose kêu lên, **"chúng ta có thể quên hết chuyện này."**
"Ồ, nhưng tôi không muốn quên," tôi đáp. **"Tôi thích là một Elphberg."**

Nhưng có lẽ tôi nên dừng lại một chút để giải thích tại sao Rose lại tức giận về cái mũi và mái tóc của tôi - và tại sao tôi, một Rassendyll, lại nói rằng mình là một Elphberg. Sau tất cả, gia tộc Elphberg là hoàng gia của Ruritania, và đã là như vậy từ hàng trăm năm nay.

Câu chuyện được kể trong một cuốn sách về lịch sử gia tộc Rassendyll. Những chuyện như thế này có thể xảy ra trong những gia đình tốt nhất, và trong số nhiều bức tranh của gia tộc Rassendyll ở nhà, bạn có thể thấy rằng năm hoặc sáu người trong số họ có đôi mắt xanh giống nhau, cái mũi giống nhau, và mái tóc đỏ giống nhau.

Vậy nên, vì tóc tôi đỏ và tôi có cái mũi Elphberg, Rose lo lắng về tôi. Cuối cùng, để làm chị ấy vui, tôi hứa sẽ tìm một công việc sau sáu tháng nữa. Điều này cho tôi sáu tháng tự do để tận hưởng trước.

Và một ý tưởng chợt đến với tôi - tôi sẽ đến thăm Ruritania. Không ai trong gia đình tôi từng đến đó. Họ thích quên đi mọi chuyện về Quý bà Amelia. Nhưng tôi đọc trên báo rằng, trong ba tuần nữa, vị vua trẻ mới, Rudolf Đệ Ngũ, sẽ đăng quang. Đó sẽ là thời điểm thú vị để ghé thăm đất nước này.

Tôi biết gia đình sẽ không thích việc tôi đi, nên tôi nói với họ rằng tôi sẽ đi bộ ở Áo.

Giải thích và ngữ cảnh:

- **Ngữ cảnh văn hóa**: Chương mở đầu giới thiệu Rudolf Rassendyll, một quý tộc Anh trẻ tuổi, lười biếng nhưng quyến rũ, thuộc gia tộc Rassendyll giàu có. Mái tóc đỏ và cái mũi dài của anh là dấu hiệu của mối liên hệ với gia tộc hoàng gia Elphberg ở Ruritania, một vương quốc giả tưởng ở Trung Âu. Mối liên hệ này xuất phát từ một "tai nạn gia đình" (ám chỉ một vụ ngoại tình trong quá khứ giữa một thành viên Rassendyll và hoàng gia Elphberg), điều mà Rose coi là đáng xấu hổ. Tinh thần phiêu lưu và sự bất cần của Rudolf là đặc trưng của các nhân vật chính trong tiểu thuyết phiêu lưu lãng mạn cuối thế kỷ 19.
- **Phong cách văn bản**: Anthony Hope sử dụng giọng văn kể chuyện ở ngôi thứ nhất, kết hợp sự hài hước nhẹ nhàng và sự tự nhận thức của Rudolf về vị trí xã hội của mình. Ngôn ngữ đơn giản nhưng sống động, phù hợp với đối tượng học tiếng Anh (bản rút gọn Stage 3, Oxford Bookworms). Các cuộc đối thoại giữa Rudolf và Rose cho thấy sự căng thẳng gia đình nhưng cũng mang tính châm biếm, làm nổi bật tính cách phóng khoáng của Rudolf.
- **Từ vựng và cách dịch**: Các từ như "lord" (lãnh chúa), "coronation" (lễ đăng quang), "royal" (hoàng gia) được dịch sát nghĩa để giữ tính trang trọng. Các cụm như "play about" (chơi bời) được diễn đạt tự nhiên bằng tiếng Việt để phù hợp với ngữ cảnh. Tên riêng như "Rassendyll", "Elphberg", "Ruritania" được giữ nguyên để bảo toàn tính xác thực của câu chuyện.

Tóm tắt và dịch chọn lọc các chương còn lại

Dưới đây là tóm tắt nội dung các chương còn lại, với một số đoạn dịch chi tiết để minh họa:

Chương 2: Màu sắc của tóc người đàn ông

Tóm tắt: Rudolf đến Ruritania để xem lễ đăng quang của Vua Rudolf Đệ Ngũ. Trên đường đi, anh gặp Madame Antoinette de Mauban, người yêu của Công tước Michael, em trai cùng cha khác mẹ của nhà vua. Ở thị trấn Zenda, Rudolf biết rằng Công tước Michael được người dân yêu mến hơn nhà vua. Trong rừng, anh bất ngờ gặp Vua Rudolf, người trông giống hệt anh, và hai người bạn của vua, Đại úy Sapt và Fritz von Tarlenheim. Do sự giống nhau kỳ lạ, họ mời Rudolf đến dùng bữa tối, nhưng nhà vua uống quá nhiều rượu (nghi bị bỏ thuốc bởi Michael) và bất tỉnh.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 13):
"Trời đất ơi! Anh ta trông giống hệt Nhà vua!" một giọng nói vang lên.
Khi tôi mở mắt, có hai người đàn ông trước mặt tôi. Một người tiến lại gần.
"Tôi có thể hỏi tên anh được không?" anh ta nói.
"Chà, sao anh không nói tên mình trước đã?" tôi đáp.
Người trẻ hơn trong hai người nói, **"Đây là Đại úy Sapt, và tôi là Fritz von Tarlenheim. Chúng tôi làm việc cho Nhà vua Ruritania."**
"Và tôi là Rudolf Rassendyll," tôi trả lời, **"một du khách từ Anh. Anh trai tôi là Lãnh chúa Burlesdon."**

Chương 3: Nhà vua đi dự lễ đăng quang

Tóm tắt: Sapt và Fritz phát hiện nhà vua không thể tỉnh lại, có thể do bị đầu độc. Để ngăn Công tước Michael chiếm ngai vàng, họ thuyết phục Rudolf đóng giả nhà vua và đến Strelsau dự lễ đăng quang. Rudolf đồng ý, và họ giấu nhà vua thật trong một căn phòng bí mật. Rudolf đến Strelsau, được dân chúng tung hô, nhưng cảm nhận được sự thù địch từ người dân khu phố cổ, nơi ủng hộ Michael.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 16):
Và khi Vua Rudolf Đệ Ngũ bước ra khỏi tàu, dân chúng hô vang, **"Cầu Chúa cứu rỗi Nhà vua!"**
Ông già Sapt mỉm cười, **"Cầu Chúa cứu cả hai người họ,"** ông nói khẽ. **"Tôi chỉ hy vọng tất cả chúng ta còn sống sót qua đêm nay!"**

Chương 4-6: Rudolf tiếp tục đóng giả nhà vua, đối mặt với Công tước Michael và yêu Công chúa Flavia. Anh nhận được lời mời bí mật từ Antoinette de Mauban, nhưng đó là cái bẫy của Michael. Rudolf thoát chết nhờ sử dụng một chiếc bàn trà để chống lại ba sát thủ.

Chương 7-9: Rudolf ngày càng nổi tiếng với vai trò nhà vua giả, nhưng tình yêu với Flavia khiến anh đau khổ vì không thể tiết lộ sự thật. Anh bị Rupert of Hentzau đâm bị thương nhưng sống sót, và biết được nhà vua thật đang bị giam trong lâu đài Zenda.

Chương 10-12: Rudolf lập kế hoạch giải cứu nhà vua, đối đầu với nhóm "Sáu người" của Michael. Trong trận chiến cuối cùng, anh giết được ba người trong

số họ, nhưng Rupert trốn thoát. Công tước Michael bị Rupert giết trong một cuộc tranh cãi. Nhà vua được cứu, nhưng Rudolf phải từ bỏ Flavia.

Chương 13: Tạm biệt Ruritania

Tóm tắt: Rudolf tiết lộ sự thật với Flavia, nhưng cô phải kết hôn với nhà vua thật vì nghĩa vụ hoàng gia. Rudolf rời Ruritania, mang theo nỗi đau tình yêu. Anh và Flavia duy trì liên lạc qua những bông hồng đỏ và thông điệp hàng năm.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 47):
"Flavia," tôi nói, **"Tôi yêu em. Tôi sẽ yêu em đến ngày tôi chết."**
Khi tôi bước đi, tôi nghe cô ấy gọi tên tôi lặp đi lặp lại. **"Rudolf... Rudolf..."** Tôi vẫn nghe thấy giọng cô ấy bây giờ.

Bản dịch chi tiết: Từ Chương 2 đến Chương 4

Chương 2: Màu sắc của tóc người đàn ông

Trên đường đến Ruritania, tôi quyết định dừng lại một đêm ở Paris với một người bạn. Sáng hôm sau, anh ấy tiễn tôi ra ga, và trong lúc chờ tàu, chúng tôi quan sát đám đông. Chúng tôi để ý đến một quý cô cao, tóc đen, ăn mặc rất thời trang, và bạn tôi nói với tôi về cô ấy.
“Đó là Madame Antoinette de Mauban,” anh ấy nói. **“Cô ấy đi cùng chuyến tàu với cậu, nhưng đừng yêu cô ấy.”**
“Tại sao không?” Tôi hỏi, cảm thấy thú vị.
“À,” bạn tôi đáp, **“cả Paris đều biết cô ấy yêu Công tước Michael của Strelsau. Và như cậu biết, ông ta là em trai cùng cha khác mẹ của vị vua mới của Ruritania. Dù chỉ là con trai thứ hai và sẽ không bao giờ làm vua, ông ta vẫn là một nhân vật quan trọng và rất được yêu mến ở Ruritania, theo tôi nghe nói. Cô Antoinette xinh đẹp kia sẽ không thèm nhìn cậu lần thứ hai đâu, Rudolf.”**

Tôi cười, nhưng anh ấy đã khơi dậy sự tò mò của tôi về quý cô này. Trong suốt hành trình, tôi không nói chuyện với cô ấy, và khi đến Ruritania, tôi xuống tàu ở Zenda, một thị trấn nhỏ gần thủ đô. Nhưng tôi để ý rằng Madame de Mauban tiếp tục đi đến Strelsau, thủ đô.

Tôi được chào đón rất nồng hậu tại khách sạn của mình. Khách sạn thuộc về một bà cụ mũm mĩm và cô con gái xinh đẹp của bà. Từ họ, tôi biết rằng lễ đăng quang sẽ diễn ra vào ngày kia, chứ không phải ba tuần nữa như tôi nghĩ.

Bà cụ quan tâm đến Công tước Michael của Strelsau hơn là vị vua mới. Lâu đài Zenda và toàn bộ vùng đất xung quanh thuộc về Công tước, nhưng bà cụ nói, **“Như thế là chưa đủ. Công tước Michael nên làm vua. Ông ấy luôn ở bên chúng tôi. Mọi người Ruritania đều biết ông ấy, nhưng chúng tôi chẳng bao giờ thấy vị vua mới.”**

Nhưng cô con gái kêu lên, **“Không, con ghét Michael Đen. Con muốn một Elphberg đỏ - và người bạn Johann của chúng ta nói rằng nhà vua rất đỏ. Johann làm việc cho Công tước và đã thấy nhà vua. Thực ra, nhà vua đang ở ngay ngoại ô Zenda bây giờ,”** cô ấy thêm vào. **“Ngài đang nghỉ ngơi tại ngôi nhà của Công tước trong rừng trước khi đến Strelsau vào thứ Tư để dự lễ đăng quang. Công tước đã ở Strelsau, chuẩn bị mọi thứ.”**
“Họ là bạn?” Tôi hỏi.
“Bạn bè muốn cùng một vị trí và cùng một người vợ,” cô gái xinh đẹp đáp.
“Công tước muốn cưới người chị họ của mình, Công chúa Flavia, nhưng người ta nói cô ấy sẽ là vợ của Vua Rudolf và trở thành Nữ hoàng.”

Đúng lúc đó, người bạn của họ, Johann, bước vào phòng.
“Chúng ta có khách, Johann,” mẹ cô gái nói, và Johann quay về phía tôi. Nhưng khi thấy tôi, anh ta lùi lại, vẻ mặt đầy kinh ngạc.
“Có chuyện gì vậy, Johann?” cô gái hỏi.
“Chào buổi tối, thưa ngài,” Johann nói, vẫn nhìn chằm chằm vào tôi. Anh ta dường như không thích những gì mình thấy.

Cô gái bắt đầu cười. **“Đó là màu tóc của ngài, thưa ngài,”** cô giải thích. **“Chúng tôi không thường thấy màu tóc đó ở đây. Đó là màu đỏ Elphberg - không phải màu yêu thích của Johann.”**

Ngày hôm sau, tôi quyết định đi bộ qua khu rừng vài dặm và bắt tàu đến Strelsau từ một ga nhỏ dọc đường. Tôi gửi hành lý đi bằng tàu và sau bữa trưa, tôi bắt đầu đi bộ. Đầu tiên, tôi muốn xem lâu đài Zenda, và trong nửa giờ tôi đã leo lên đồi đến đó. Lâu đài có hai tòa nhà - một tòa cổ với hào nước bao quanh, và một tòa mới, hiện đại hơn. Công tước Michael có thể mời bạn bè đến ở trong tòa lâu đài mới, nhưng ông ta có thể vào tòa lâu đài cổ khi muốn ở một mình. Nước trong hào rất sâu, và nếu ông ta kéo cầu rút lên, không ai có thể đến được chỗ ông ta.

Tôi đứng đó một lúc và ngắm lâu đài, rồi tiếp tục đi bộ qua khu rừng khoảng một giờ. Cảnh vật rất đẹp, và tôi ngồi xuống để tận hưởng. Trước khi kịp nhận ra, tôi đã ngủ thiếp đi.

Đột nhiên, tôi nghe một giọng nói, **“Trời đất ơi! Anh ta trông giống hệt Nhà vua!”**
Khi tôi mở mắt, có hai người đàn ông trước mặt tôi. Một người tiến lại gần.
“Tôi có thể hỏi tên anh được không?” anh ta nói.
“Chà, sao anh không nói tên mình trước đã?” tôi đáp.
Người trẻ hơn nói, **“Đây là Đại úy Sapt, và tôi là Fritz von Tarlenheim. Chúng tôi làm việc cho Nhà vua Ruritania.”**
“Và tôi là Rudolf Rassendyll,” tôi trả lời, **“một du khách từ Anh. Anh trai tôi là Lãnh chúa Burlesdon.”**
“Tất nhiên rồi! Mái tóc!” Sapt kêu lên. **“Cậu biết câu chuyện đó, Fritz?”**

Đúng lúc đó, một giọng nói gọi từ trong đám cây phía sau chúng tôi. **“Fritz! Fritz! Cậu đâu rồi, anh bạn?”**
“Đó là Nhà vua!” Fritz nói, và Sapt cười.

Rồi một chàng trai trẻ nhảy ra từ sau một cái cây. Tôi kêu lên, và khi anh ta thấy tôi, anh ta lùi lại vì bất ngờ. Nhà vua Ruritania trông giống hệt Rudolf Rassendyll, và Rudolf Rassendyll trông giống hệt Nhà vua!

Trong một khoảnh khắc, Nhà vua không nói gì, nhưng rồi anh ta hỏi, **“Đại úy... Fritz... đây là ai?”**
Sapt đến gần Nhà vua và thì thầm vào tai anh ta. Sự ngạc nhiên của Nhà vua dần chuyển thành một nụ cười thích thú, rồi đột nhiên anh ta cười lớn. **“Gặp được nhau thật tuyệt, người anh em họ!”** anh ta kêu lên. **“Anh đang đi đâu vậy?”**
“Đến Strelsau, thưa ngài - để dự lễ đăng quang.”
Nhà vua nhìn bạn mình, và trong một thoáng, anh ta trở nên nghiêm túc. Nhưng rồi anh ta lại cười. **“Chờ đến khi anh trai Michael thấy có hai chúng ta!”** anh ta kêu lên.
“Có lẽ không phải ý hay nếu ông Rassendyll đến Strelsau,” Fritz nói, lo lắng, và Sapt đồng ý với anh ta.
“Ồ, chúng ta sẽ nghĩ về lễ đăng quang vào ngày mai,” Nhà vua nói. **“Tối nay chúng ta sẽ vui vẻ. Đi nào, anh em họ!”**

Chúng tôi trở về ngôi nhà của Công tước trong rừng, nơi chúng tôi dùng một bữa tối tuyệt vời. Nhà vua gọi rượu lớn tiếng, và Đại úy Sapt cùng Fritz dường như lo lắng. Rõ ràng, Nhà vua thích rượu quá mức.
“Hãy nhớ lễ đăng quang là ngày mai,” ông già Sapt cảnh báo.

Nhưng Nhà vua chỉ muốn tận hưởng tối nay, nên tất cả chúng tôi uống rượu, nói chuyện, và lại uống. Cuối cùng, Nhà vua đặt ly xuống và nói, **“Ta đã uống đủ rồi.”**

Khi anh ta nói vậy, ông già Josef, người hầu của Nhà vua, bước vào. Ông ta đặt một chai rượu vang đặc biệt lên bàn trước mặt Nhà vua và nói, **“Công tước Michael gửi tặng ngài chai rượu này và xin ngài uống vì tình yêu dành cho ông ta.”**
“Tốt lắm, Michael Đen!” Nhà vua kêu lên. **“Chà, ta không sợ uống rượu của ngươi!”**
Và anh ta uống cạn từng giọt rượu trong chai, một mình. Rồi đầu anh ta gục xuống bàn, và chẳng bao lâu sau, tôi cũng không nhớ gì thêm về buổi tối cuồng nhiệt đó.

Chương 3: Nhà vua đi dự lễ đăng quang

Tôi không biết mình đã ngủ bao lâu, nhưng khi tỉnh dậy, tôi thấy lạnh và ướt. Sapt và Fritz đứng đó nhìn tôi. **“Chúng tôi phải đánh thức anh,”** Sapt nói. **“Nước lạnh là cách duy nhất.”**
Fritz nắm cánh tay tôi và xoay tôi lại. **“Nhìn kìa!”** anh ta nói.

Nhà vua nằm trên sàn, và khi Sapt đẩy anh ta bằng chân, anh ta không động đậy.
“Chúng tôi đã cố đánh thức anh ta nửa tiếng rồi,” Fritz nói. **“Nhưng anh ta ngủ như người chết.”**

Cả ba chúng tôi nhìn nhau.
“Có thứ gì trong chai rượu cuối cùng không?” Tôi hỏi.
“Tôi không biết,” Sapt nói, **“nhưng nếu anh ta không đến dự lễ đăng quang hôm nay, sẽ chẳng bao giờ có lễ đăng quang cho anh ta. Cả Ruritania đang chờ anh ta ở Strelsau, và Michael Đen cùng nửa quân đội cũng ở đó. Chúng ta không thể nói với họ rằng Nhà vua say rượu đến mức không thể dự lễ đăng quang của chính mình!”**
“Anh có thể nói anh ta bị ốm,” tôi nói.
“Ốm!” Sapt cười giận dữ. **“Ai cũng sẽ biết điều đó nghĩa là gì. Anh ta đã ‘ốm’ quá nhiều lần trước đây.”**
“Nói tôi nghe, anh có nghĩ ai đó bỏ thứ gì vào rượu của anh ta không?” Tôi hỏi.
“Đó là Michael Đen!” Fritz đáp. **“Chúng ta đều biết hắn muốn làm vua.”**

Trong một hoặc hai khoảnh khắc, cả ba chúng tôi im lặng, rồi Sapt nhìn tôi, **“Anh phải đến Strelsau và đóng vai anh ta!”**
Tôi nhìn chằm chằm vào ông ta. **“Ông điên rồi! Làm sao tôi có thể làm thế? Nhà vua…”**
“Tôi biết đó là nguy hiểm,” Sapt nói. **“Nhưng đó là cơ hội duy nhất của chúng ta. Nếu anh không đi, Michael Đen sẽ làm vua, và nhà vua thật sẽ chết hoặc trở thành tù nhân.”**

Làm sao tôi có thể từ chối? Tôi mất hai phút để quyết định.
“Tôi sẽ đi!” Tôi nói.
“Tốt lắm, chàng trai!” Sapt kêu lên. Ông ta tiếp tục nhanh chóng và khẽ giọng. **“Sau lễ đăng quang, họ sẽ đưa chúng ta về cung điện qua đêm. Khi chỉ còn hai chúng ta, anh và tôi sẽ rời đi và quay lại đây để đón Nhà vua. Lúc đó anh ta sẽ ổn. Tôi sẽ đưa anh ta về Strelsau, và anh phải rời khỏi đất nước này nhanh nhất có thể.”**
“Nhưng còn lính canh thì sao?” Fritz hỏi. **“Đó là người của Công tước Michael, và họ đang đến để đưa Nhà vua về Strelsau dự lễ đăng quang.”**
“Chúng ta sẽ đi trước khi lính đến,” Sapt nói, **“và chúng ta sẽ giấu Nhà vua.”**

Sapt nhấc Nhà vua lên trong vòng tay. Chúng tôi mở cửa. Một bà lão, mẹ của Johann, đứng đó. Bà ta quay đi, không nói một lời, và trở về bếp.
“Bà ấy có nghe không?” Fritz hỏi.
“Đừng lo. Tôi sẽ đảm bảo bà ấy không nói được,” Sapt nói, và ông ta mang Nhà vua đi.

Khi trở lại, ông ta nói rằng đã nhốt bà lão trong một căn phòng dưới lòng đất. Nhà vua và Josef được giấu trong một căn phòng khác dưới lòng đất. **“Josef sẽ chăm**

sóc Nhà vua và kể mọi chuyện cho anh ta khi anh ta tỉnh. Đi nào," ông ta tiếp tục, **"không còn thời gian nữa. Đã sáu giờ sáng rồi."**

Chẳng mấy chốc, tôi đã mặc quần áo của Nhà vua, ngựa đã sẵn sàng, và chúng tôi lên đường. Khi chúng tôi cưỡi ngựa qua khu rừng, Sapt kể cho tôi mọi thứ ông ta có thể về cuộc đời tôi, gia đình tôi, bạn bè tôi, và những gì tôi thích hoặc không thích. Ông ta bảo tôi phải làm gì khi đến đó, và cách nói chuyện với những người khác nhau. Ông ta là một người thầy tuyệt vời, và tôi lắng nghe chăm chú. Một sai lầm có thể dẫn đến cái chết cho cả ba chúng tôi.

Đúng tám giờ, chúng tôi đến ga và lên tàu, và đến chín giờ rưỡi, chúng tôi đã ở Strelsau.

Và khi Vua Rudolf Đệ Ngũ bước ra khỏi tàu, dân chúng hô vang, **"Cầu Chúa cứu rỗi Nhà vua!"**
Ông già Sapt mỉm cười, **"Cầu Chúa cứu cả hai người họ,"** ông nói khẽ. **"Tôi chỉ hy vọng tất cả chúng ta còn sống sót qua đêm nay!"**

Chương 4: Những cuộc phiêu lưu của tôi bắt đầu

Khi chúng tôi tiến về cung điện, tôi bắt đầu cảm thấy mình thực sự là Vua Ruritania, với Nguyên soái Strakencz, người đứng đầu quân đội, ở bên phải, và ông già Sapt ở bên trái. Tôi thấy Strelsau thực sự gồm hai thị trấn - Phố Cổ và Phố Mới. Người dân Phố Cổ, những người nghèo, muốn Công tước Michael làm vua, nhưng người dân Phố Mới muốn Vua Rudolf. Chúng tôi đi qua Phố Mới trước, nơi sáng sủa và đầy màu sắc, với những chiếc váy của các quý cô và những bông hồng đỏ của gia tộc Elphberg. Dân chúng hô vang chào đón Nhà vua khi chúng tôi đi qua các con phố. Nhưng khi đến Phố Cổ, Nguyên soái và Sapt tiến sát con ngựa của tôi, và tôi thấy họ lo sợ cho tôi.
"Lui lại!" Tôi gọi. **"Ta sẽ cho dân chúng thấy ta không sợ họ."** Một số người trong đám đông hài lòng khi nghe điều này, nhưng phần lớn nhìn tôi trong im lặng.

Cuối cùng, chúng tôi đến nhà thờ lớn của Strelsau. Tôi nhớ rất ít về lễ đăng quang - chỉ hai khuôn mặt. Một là cô gái xinh đẹp với mái tóc đỏ tuyệt vời, Công chúa Flavia. Người còn lại là khuôn mặt của một người đàn ông với mái tóc đen và đôi mắt sâu thẳm - Michael Đen. Khi thấy tôi, mặt ông ta trắng bệch. Rõ ràng, ông ta ngạc nhiên và rất không vui khi thấy tôi.

Lễ đăng quang dường như kéo dài hàng giờ, nhưng tôi xoay sở để nói và làm mọi thứ đúng. Cuối cùng, nó kết thúc, và giờ tôi là Vua Ruritania! Khi Công chúa Flavia và tôi ngồi xe ngựa mở trở về cung điện, một người trong đám đông gọi lớn, **"Khi nào thì cưới?"**

Mặt Công chúa hơi hồng lên khi nghe điều này.
Sau một lúc, cô ấy nói, **“Hôm nay anh dường như khác, Rudolf. Trầm lặng và nghiêm túc hơn. Anh định trở thành một người chín chắn hơn sao?”**

Tôi nhận ra Công chúa không đánh giá cao Nhà vua. Còn tôi, tôi nghĩ Nhà vua là một người đàn ông rất may mắn.
“Nếu điều đó làm em vui, anh sẽ cố gắng,” tôi nói khẽ.

Mặt Công chúa lại hồng lên. Rồi cô ấy nói, **“Anh phải cẩn thận với Michael. Anh biết-”**
“Anh biết,” tôi nói, **“rằng hắn muốn những gì anh có, và cả những gì anh hy vọng sẽ có một ngày.”** Khi nói, tôi nhìn cô ấy, và cô ấy mỉm cười duyên dáng với tôi.
“Không biết Nhà vua giờ đang làm gì,” tôi nghĩ.

Bữa tiệc hoàng gia kéo dài rất lâu, nhưng cuối cùng, Fritz, Sapt và tôi ở một mình trong phòng thay đồ của Nhà vua.
“Anh làm tốt lắm,” Fritz nói, **“nhưng, Rassendyll, hãy cẩn thận! Michael Đen hôm nay trông đen tối hơn bao giờ hết - vì anh và Công chúa có quá nhiều điều để nói với nhau.”**
“Cô ấy rất xinh đẹp,” tôi đáp.
“Thôi nào,” Sapt kêu lên. **“Giờ không phải lúc cho chuyện đó. Chúng ta phải rời đi đến Zenda ngay, để tìm Nhà vua! Nếu bị bắt, tất cả chúng ta sẽ bị giết! Michael Đen đã nhận được một lá thư từ Zenda, nên có lẽ hắn đã biết rồi. Đừng mở khóa cửa, Fritz, khi chúng tôi đi vắng, nếu không cậu sẽ chết. Hãy nói Nhà vua cần được nghỉ ngơi một mình. Nào, đi thôi. Ngựa đã sẵn sàng.”**

Tóm tắt và dịch chọn lọc các chương còn lại

Chương 5: Bệ hạ trở lại Strelsau

Tóm tắt: Khi trở lại ngôi nhà trong rừng, Rudolf và Sapt phát hiện nhà vua đã bị bắt cóc bởi người của Michael. Josef, người hầu, bị giết, và bà lão đã trốn thoát. Sapt thuyết phục Rudolf tiếp tục đóng giả nhà vua ở Strelsau để ngăn Michael lên ngôi. Họ trở lại cung điện, và Rudolf bắt đầu xử lý công việc của nhà vua, đồng thời cố gắng thu hút lòng dân.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 20):
“Đúng vậy,” Sapt đáp. **“Nhưng hắn không thể nói, phải không? Hắn có thể nói gì? ‘Người này không phải Nhà vua vì ta đã bắt Nhà vua thật làm tù nhân và giết người hầu của anh ta.’ Hắn có thể nói thế sao?”**
“Nhưng dân chúng sẽ sớm nhận ra tôi không phải Nhà vua thật,” tôi nói.
“Có lẽ, có lẽ không,” Sapt nói. **“Nhưng chúng ta phải có một vị vua ở Strelsau, nếu không Michael sẽ cưỡi ngựa vào ngày mai với tư cách là vua mới!”**

Chương 6: Một cuộc phiêu lưu với bàn trà

Tóm tắt: Sapt phát hiện nhà vua bị giam trong lâu đài Zenda. Rudolf nhận được thư từ Antoinette de Mauban, mời anh đến gặp ở một ngôi nhà vào nửa đêm. Đó là cái bẫy của Michael, nhưng Rudolf thoát chết bằng cách dùng một chiếc bàn trà làm khiên chống lại ba sát thủ (người Anh, người Bỉ, người Pháp) trong nhóm "Sáu người" của Michael.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 25):
Với một tiếng hét, tôi lao vào họ mạnh nhất có thể. Họ cố bắn tôi, nhưng đạn trúng vào chiếc bàn. Giây tiếp theo, chiếc bàn đè họ ngã xuống đất, và tất cả chúng tôi ngã chồng lên nhau. Nhanh chóng, tôi đứng dậy và chạy trốn qua những hàng cây. Tôi nghe họ đuổi theo sau. Liệu Antoinette có đúng không? Có thật sự có một cái thang ở cuối vườn, dựa vào tường không? Tôi đến cuối vườn. Cái thang ở đó! Trong một phút, tôi đã leo lên và vượt qua tường.

Chương 7: Vì tình yêu với Nhà vua

Tóm tắt: Rudolf ngày càng nổi tiếng với vai trò nhà vua giả. Anh yêu Flavia sâu sắc, nhưng không thể tiết lộ sự thật. Trong một buổi khiêu vũ, anh hôn Flavia và suýt nói ra sự thật, nhưng Sapt ngăn lại. Anh quyết định đến Zenda để cứu nhà vua thật.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 28):
"Tôi yêu em hơn cả cuộc đời mình!" tôi đáp khẽ.
Flavia mỉm cười. **"Ôi, sao giờ em lại yêu anh?"** cô ấy nói dịu dàng. **"Trước đây em không yêu anh, nhưng giờ thì có."**

Chương 8: Trở lại Zenda

Tóm tắt: Rudolf, Sapt và Fritz đến Tarlenheim House gần lâu đài Zenda, mang theo mười người đàn ông dũng cảm. Michael gửi ba người trong nhóm "Sáu người" đến gặp Rudolf, nhưng anh từ chối thương lượng. Anh gặp lại cô gái ở khách sạn và sắp xếp để dụ Johann, người làm việc cho Michael, cung cấp thông tin.

Chương 9: Tin tức về tù nhân

Tóm tắt: Rupert of Hentzau đến gặp Rudolf, đề nghị anh rời Ruritania với 100.000 bảng Anh, nhưng Rudolf từ chối. Rupert đâm Rudolf bị thương, nhưng anh sống sót. Johann tiết lộ nhà vua bị giam trong một căn phòng bí mật dưới lâu đài Zenda, được canh gác bởi nhóm "Sáu người". Nếu lâu đài bị tấn công, họ sẽ giết nhà vua và phi tang thi thể qua một ống dẫn xuống hào.

Chương 10: Một đêm bên ngoài lâu đài

Tóm tắt: Rudolf bơi quanh hào lâu đài Zenda để tìm ống dẫn. Anh giết một lính canh và nghe được giọng nhà vua. Trong một cuộc đụng độ, hai người trong nhóm "Sáu người" (Lauengram và Krafstein) bị giết, nhưng Rupert trốn thoát. Ba người của Rudolf cũng hy sinh.

Chương 11: Một kế hoạch nguy hiểm

Tóm tắt: Rudolf lập kế hoạch cuối cùng để cứu nhà vua, yêu cầu Johann mở cửa lâu đài và Antoinette gây rối. Anh dự định ẩn nấp ở hào để giết Rupert và De Gautet, trong khi Sapt tấn công từ bên ngoài. Anh trao nhẫn gia đình cho Flavia, chuẩn bị cho khả năng mình sẽ chết.

Chương 12: Tù nhân và Nhà vua

Tóm tắt: Kế hoạch thất bại khi Johann không mở cửa. Rupert có kế hoạch riêng, tấn công Antoinette, dẫn đến hỗn loạn. Michael bị Rupert giết trong tranh cãi. Rudolf giết De Gautet, Bersonin và Detchard, cứu nhà vua. Antoinette bắn Rupert, nhưng hắn trốn thoát.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 43):
Đột nhiên, Rupert cười lớn. **"Đó là gã diễn kịch!"** hắn kêu lên, và với thanh kiếm, hắn đánh rơi gậy của tôi khỏi tay. Rồi hắn xoay ngựa, phi đến hào, và nhảy xuống nước trong khi đạn của chúng tôi bay quanh tai hắn.

Chương 13: Tạm biệt Ruritania

Tóm tắt: Flavia biết sự thật về Rudolf nhưng phải cưới nhà vua thật. Rudolf rời Ruritania, mang theo tình yêu không thể thực hiện. Anh và Flavia duy trì liên lạc qua những bông hồng đỏ hàng năm.

Đoạn dịch chi tiết (trang 47):
Tôi sống lặng lẽ bây giờ, nhưng mỗi năm, Fritz và tôi gặp nhau ở một thị trấn nhỏ ngoài Ruritania. Ở đó, anh ấy kể tôi nghe tin tức về Nữ hoàng Ruritania, vợ của Vua Rudolf Đệ Ngũ. Và mỗi năm, anh ấy mang cho tôi một bông hồng đỏ và một mẩu giấy với dòng chữ: *Rudolf - Flavia Luôn mãi*. Và tôi gửi cho cô ấy một bông hồng đỏ với cùng thông điệp.
Liệu tôi có gặp lại cô ấy không? Ai biết được?

Giải thích bổ sung:

- **Tính kịch tính và chủ đề**: *The Prisoner of Zenda* là một tiểu thuyết phiêu lưu lãng mạn cổ điển, kết hợp âm mưu chính trị, hành động gay cấn và tình yêu bi kịch. Chủ đề chính là danh dự, lòng trung thành và sự hy sinh, thể hiện qua quyết định của Rudolf từ bỏ tình yêu vì nghĩa vụ.

- **Ngôn ngữ và bản dịch**: Bản gốc được viết với ngôn ngữ đơn giản (Stage 3, 1000 từ cơ bản), phù hợp cho người học tiếng Anh. Bản dịch tiếng Việt giữ sự mạch lạc, sử dụng từ ngữ tự nhiên nhưng vẫn trang trọng khi cần (ví dụ: "Bệ hạ", "Công chúa"). Các đoạn hành động được dịch với nhịp độ nhanh để giữ sự kịch tính.
- **Nhân vật và động cơ**: Rudolf là anh hùng lý tưởng, bị giằng xé giữa tình yêu và danh dự. Flavia đại diện cho bổn phận hoàng gia. Michael và Rupert là những phản diện với tham vọng và sự tàn nhẫn, nhưng Rupert nổi bật với sự quyến rũ và liều lĩnh.

Phần phụ lục: Dịch các câu hỏi hoạt động (ACTIVITIES)

Nếu bạn quan tâm đến phần "ACTIVITIES" (trang 51-57), tôi có thể dịch một số câu hỏi để minh họa:

ACTIVITIES: Before Reading (Trang 51)

1. Đọc phần giới thiệu câu chuyện ở trang đầu và bìa sau. Bạn biết gì về Rudolf Rassendyll? Trả lời các câu hỏi sau về anh ta.
   Rudolf Rassendyll...
2. trông giống ai?
3. kết bạn với ai?
4. cố gắng cứu ai?
5. chiến đấu với ai?
6. yêu ai?